PROTAGONIST GUIDE TO RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction **4**

Friendships **5**

Protagonists Friendships by Role 7

Protagonist–Analyst Friendships 7

Protagonist–Diplomat Friendships 12

Protagonist–Sentinel Friendships 17

Protagonist–Explorer Friendships 22

Conclusion. 27

Romantic Relationships **29**

Potential Pairings by Role 31

Protagonist–Analyst Relationships 31

Protagonist–Diplomat Relationships . . . 37

Protagonist–Sentinel Relationships 45

Protagonist–Explorer Relationships 51

Conclusion. 56

Parenthood **58**

Parenting for Each Stage of Development . . 61

Building Bonds (from Birth to Approximately 1½ Years) 61

Testing Boundaries (from Approximately 1½ to 3 Years) 66

Thirst for Knowledge (from Approximately 3 to 5 Years) 70

Creating Competence (from Approximately 5 to 12 Years) 75

Table of Contents

Find Thyself (from Approximately 12 to 18 Years). 79
Conclusion. 83
Final Words 85
So... What's Next? 86

Introduction

Why Relationships Matter for Protagonists

Protagonists have a sincere belief in the value of people and relationships. They're more than willing to use their time and energy to uplift others and strengthen their connections with the people around them – in fact, Protagonists can imagine few endeavors that would be *more* worthy of their time or their energy.

The hope that Protagonists have for humanity isn't an abstract philosophy but an actively lived experience. Engaging with other people lights Protagonists up. When someone shares their innermost opinions and thoughts and dreams with them, Protagonists consider it an honor – and then they do everything in their power to encourage that person along their path.

Challenges and Opportunities

Not everyone is equally receptive to this kind of assistance, however, and not everyone is equipped – or willing – to offer the same level of engagement in return. Protagonists may be frustrated when someone who seems to be struggling refuses to accept their help or when their friends or loved ones don't seem to be equally invested in the relationship. It isn't easy, but at times, Protagonists may find that they need to give certain people in their lives more space – including the space to learn their own lessons and make their own mistakes.

The good news is that Protagonists' warmth and caring, along with their depth, can help them to build resilient relationships that more than stand the test of time. In these pages, we'll discuss how Protagonists can enhance their friendships, their romantic relationships, and – if they become parents – their relationships with their children. Along the way, we'll cover how Protagonists can develop balanced, meaningful connections, even with people who are quite different from themselves.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Friendships

Deep and Strong

People with the Protagonist personality type bring inspired energy to their friendships, as with all the other pursuits in their lives. Their enthusiasm is contagious, and these outgoing people draw their friends into exciting fun when given half a chance. When Protagonists find other people who enjoy the same kind of activities, they form warm and caring friendships. Their sincerity can create extraordinary kinship so honest and profound that it feels as strong as a family tie.

In addition to their closest friends, this type is also happy to engage a broad swathe of people. Outgoing and bold, Protagonists form casual friendships very quickly and easily. However, compromise isn't something these idealists do easily, so they weed out those who don't share the depth of their idealism, or at least relegate them to the status of "acquaintance."

Protagonists possess an aura of thoughtful support that naturally confers influence and draws other people to them. They may even become the center of their chosen social groups, reveling in the trust and admiration that their friends have for them. In return, Protagonists offer their friends unending support and care from the heart. It's more than just noble sincerity – Protagonists are energetic and, quite simply, a lot of fun. Those lucky enough to become good friends with them find great joy and adventures in their company.

Exceptional Expectations

Although gregarious, people with this personality type can also be exacting, obsessed with their ideas, the future, and musings about what the world – and they themselves – might become. Taken to an excessive degree, this drive can take the form of stringent expectations that create an imposing social barrier to some people. If someone strays too far from Protagonists' ideals, they may try to pull the person back – and that effort is not always welcome. What Protagonists demand is exhausting for many other types, and it may clash with their friends' vision for themselves.

When Protagonists expect unrealistically perfect friendships, they run the risk of being disappointed. But when they try to force others to conform, they also risk pushing their friends away – no one likes to be judged. They may even forgo new friendships that, were it not for their extreme expectations, would have grown into mutually satisfying relationships. However, their generous hearts and unending desire to grow offer Protagonists a chance to see when their actions are interfering with positive connections.

Further Extending Compassion

Compassion is often the key to compromise, and Protagonists have an energetic, idealistic approach toward differences in others. People with this personality type think nothing of bending over backward to help their friends, and if they realize their own mistakes, they won't stop until they are fixed. Their own capacity for confident generosity is one of the greatest tools that Protagonists possess for forming a realistic picture of friendship, as it can bridge any difference.

Other personality types can be challenging for Protagonists, but extending compassion and accepting others enables connections with even the most seemingly incompatible types. Maturity, wisdom, and mutual respect can create rewarding friendships with any combination of personalities. Protagonists, with their ability to connect emotionally and their desire for such knowledge, are well-suited to find common ground with others through conscious acts of appreciation.

Protagonists Friendships by Role

Let's examine the challenges that Protagonists face and the joys that they experience in friendships with those belonging to each of the Roles: Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. Any pairing can be an exciting adventure for this friendly, loving type. Knowing there may be occasional glitches in potential friendships shouldn't discourage them – awareness can help them find their way along the sometimes-difficult path to meaningful friendship.

Protagonist–Analyst Friendships

Protagonists and Analysts share a marvelous ability to not only imagine many possibilities but also delve deeply into a subject, seeing its many facets. The angle from which they glimpse these facets can be heavily informed by their underlying differences, making for an exciting and intellectually stimulating friendship. When these friends keep open minds, they'll find each other to be among their most respected friends, both impressed with the sincerity and depth of each other's thoughts.

Balanced Protagonist–Analyst Friendships

Complementary Imaginations

To Protagonists, having Analyst friends can feel like an extension of their own minds but with an expanded perspective. Analysts enjoy using their rationality to play the role of creative consultant to friends – they pride themselves on their logic and impartiality. Analysts are bluntly honest, especially with their closest friends, and Protagonists may see this as a blessing and a curse. They can be irritated when Analyst friends criticize one of their pet causes or values, but they also know that checking ideas against honest critiques has value.

Possibly because they don't always agree, Protagonist and Analyst friends make quite the team when they create fun ideas together, and they love to do so. Both types have expansive imaginations, but neither necessarily uses their imagination to realistic ends: Analysts enjoy inventing complex systems and can feel satisfied with mere thought experiments. Protagonists imagine grand outcomes with little concern for how they'll achieve them, and they're always ready to jump into action.

Fortunately for these friends, their distinct traits often balance each other out. Protagonist and Analyst friends offer each other more diverse worldviews than either has alone. When they're willing to take the best of each worldview and combine them cooperatively, the combined force of their imaginations can create amazing fun together.

Balancing Each Other's Views

These friends can also help each other on a deeply personal level. With their emotions always at the fore, Protagonists excel at seeing complex human struggles in relatable ways. Analysts take a more calculated view of things, so they can help Protagonists balance passionate idealism with a bit of hard logic – and vice versa. There's quite a difference between hope and reality, but each perspective can influence the other productively as these friends help each other understand. Protagonists appreciate the difference between beating their heads against a wall and fighting the good fight, and Analysts' impartial rationality helps them keep their energy focused where it can be effective.

Analysts sometimes lose sight of the grand possibilities in life – and they're lucky when they have Protagonists to stand as examples of how faith and passion can overcome odds that appear insurmountable. The infectious enthusiasm of Protagonists helps Analysts expand their own view of what's possible, opening opportunities for fun as well as valuable personal growth. Protagonists don't let Analyst friends hide behind facts or logic, frequently pressing them to incorporate less tangible values into their picture of reality. Each of these types has a powerful mind for learning from each other, and both are better for it.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Analyst Friendships

Soured Idealism

Tension can arise from the different filters these friends use to make decisions: humanism for Protagonists versus rationalism for Analysts. Protagonists implement solutions to address human needs, but they frequently underestimate very real limits and logistical challenges, which dismays Analysts. Analysts often see society as an almost mechanical system, focusing less on the welfare of the individual pieces than the efficient functionality of the whole – a mindset that Protagonists find too cold. To Protagonists, those "pieces" are valuable human beings.

Protagonists don't appreciate challenges to their sacred values, but Analysts poke and prod instinctively in the name of exploring ideas – a recipe for arguments. When clinical rationality goes up against heartfelt passion, it can feel like a battle of morals, especially when opinions and ideas about society are the subject. Neither of these types can put their best foot forward when they dig in their heels. Instead of considering their equally valid perspectives and moving forward together with improved ideas, sometimes these types retreat into resentment.

Troubling Emotional Differences

Friendships between people of these types can also experience an empathy gap, despite their best intentions and an appreciation of each other. Protagonists are well-tuned to emotional understanding, always working to resolve upset feelings, but Analysts are rarely comfortable with showing emotions to begin with. They struggle to understand and express feelings, which often makes them seem slow, awkward, and reserved in emotional situations. When a response such as sympathy is expected by Protagonists, Analysts often flounder, leaving both friends wondering what's wrong with each other.

Protagonists may even start to resent it when Analysts try to use rationality to "fix" a situation while ignoring emotion, even viewing them as unfeeling. They may begin to pull back from their connection as friends or, worse, push more emotion on Analysts, causing them to retreat in bewilderment. If this usually innocent disconnection is not balanced with mutual understanding, it can kill any chance of deep honesty and mutual reliance in this friendship. Both friends want to care

for each other, but given their differences, they might not understand how best to do so.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Analyst Friendships

Keeping an Open Mind

When clashes occur between their styles, these friends must make a concerted effort to recapture the way that they inspire and respect each other. Protagonists and Analysts have a big advantage here: Their expansive imaginations help them understand alternative perspectives. Sharing their views comes naturally to these types – in fact, such conversations initially brought them closer, and discussions about their diverse perspectives can remain a source of fun and inspiration when refreshed with genuine respect. But conversation shouldn't necessarily be the end – these friends can show each other how their different points of view work in daily life.

Protagonist and Analyst friends can also "agree to disagree" on some things, accepting that certain subjects may never be fun to talk about together. This doesn't mean that they must always avoid friendly arguments, but when they repeatedly hit an immovable point of contention, wisdom demands that they just let it go. They can accept that differing approaches to life may work better for each of them as individuals.

Both types should understand that being right is not as important as respecting each other, so they can drop stubborn ego in favor of friendship itself. The good times they can share are a lot more fulfilling than winning an argument. In their efforts to be truly open with each other, these friends can practice the following tips during disagreements:

- When your friend expresses a point of view, stop and listen objectively before responding.
- As your friend speaks, consider whether they are presenting theory or their actual lifestyle choices. If the latter, consider that your disagreement could be tantamount to a personal indictment – and proceed gently.

- If something seems disagreeable, ask for more information – perhaps an example of how they make it work in their own lives.
- Before dismissing each other's views and lifestyles, try them out – ask for guidance on how.
- If, after giving something a fair shot and due consideration, you disagree with something, say so respectfully, stressing that it's just a personal choice, not a judgment.
- After a disagreement, reaffirm the friendship by diving immediately into an area of commonality, such as a favorite restaurant, game, or pastime.

Tolerance may not be easy for either Protagonists or Analysts, but willingness to at least briefly try on each other's views is the highest form of respect.

Equally Valuable Abilities

If Protagonists want emotional support from Analysts, they can just say so. If they're careful not to criticize Analysts as flawed, there's nothing wrong with asking for help and trading advice. Analysts deeply value their true friends, and they enjoy expanding their abilities, so Protagonists can help them understand the truth of how friends make each other feel through their behavior.

Protagonists tend to be up front and vocal about their needs, but they also need to be literal – that's how Analysts are, and it speaks to them. Whether asking Analysts to be less harsh in their presentation, more open with their feelings, or sympathetic in times of need, Protagonists are usually impressed at how quickly these types learn when motivated by friendship. Analysts are very capable of emotional evolution, especially with Protagonists serving as excellent examples.

But responsibility for keeping balance can't fall solely on Analysts – Protagonists can learn a lot from their friends about the value of a detached approach in certain situations. Sometimes delving fully into emotional responses is the equivalent of pouring gas on a fire – a reserved attitude can be just as beneficial in some moments as emotional openness is in others, and these friends can learn from each other's examples.

And of course, when either friend tries to understand the other, positive feedback is always appropriate: for example, "I really appreciate the way you try to see my perspective."

The following tips can help Protagonists resolve their emotional differences with Analysts:

- Ask for a moment to talk. Pick a place comfortable for both.
- Express the issue, whether personal or in the friendship.
- Practice emotional control; speak calmly and deliberately, and don't interrupt.
- Use "me" and "I" statements, focusing on what you need rather than on any deficits you may perceive in your friend.
- Be specific about the support you need (e.g., creative ideas, sympathetic listening, reassurance).
- When your friend provides the support you were looking for, offer positive feedback and show appreciation.

Analysts have every right to make inverted requests: They may need a break from emotional connectedness. Protagonists should remain willing to dial down their own seriousness and share in some humorous, lighthearted fun.

Protagonist–Diplomat Friendships

Close Diplomat friends often closely mirror each other, as Diplomats can be just as enthusiastic, passionate, kind, and imaginative toward each other as to other people and other types. Protagonists love to meet up for active fun together, and conversations between these

friends can be delightfully addictive. Because Diplomats are rare among the constellation of personality types, these friends try hard to maintain such precious friendships regardless of any difficulties they may face.

Balanced Protagonist–Diplomat Friendships

Friends at Heart

Protagonists who form true friendships with other Diplomats experience the wonder of gaining an intellectual and emotional extension of themselves. Both friends share experiences with and through each other, gaining the benefit and wisdom of each other's triumphs and trials. "I have the most amazing idea..." is often heard between these friends. Diplomats can motivate and support each other through life with the energy of their kindness. And in some ways, their deep communication offers them a chance to live two lives at once as they share great fun together.

Protagonist and Diplomat friends are also well-suited to care for each other in times of trouble, leaning on each other and expressing feelings freely. A deep personal knowledge of their friends' uniqueness combined with their caring nature makes them wonderful emotional resources for each other. Each knows what the other needs and when they need it. Sometimes they offer comfort and sympathy, sometimes encouragement (Protagonists may even offer a loving kick to the rear), but good Diplomat friends are always wellsprings of support.

Creativity and Excitement

The connection between these friends goes beyond emotion, encompassing realms of exciting and creative imagination as well. When Protagonists and other Diplomats share a mutual interest, they inspire each other further into it. Much of this energy comes from sharing core qualities that drive both friends in similar directions. That doesn't necessarily mean the same direction – they are, after all, unique individuals. But by weaving together harmonious but not identical paths, these friends can glimpse things from different points of view – a real gift for both.

Ideas are just the beginning of this pair's adventures. When it comes to creative pursuits, Protagonists may lead the charge, but they find

that other Diplomats make helpful partners. When these types create a trusting friendship, balance arises not just from exchanging insights and dreams, but also from sharing happy experiences. Even Introverted Diplomats find themselves drawn into adventure and excitement by Protagonists, who offer a caring energy that can motivate others to jump into life.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Diplomat Friendships

Insulating Each Other

One challenge for Protagonists and their Diplomat friends comes from the same source that fuels their friendship – their similarity. When these friends give each other too much reassurance and inspiration based on their shared perspective, it can create a bubble that isolates them from different opinions and worldviews. Protagonists' Judging trait can sometimes prevent them from being open-minded, and they may find comfort in common approaches and opinions. When these friends' agreement shields them from the world's stark differences, they may also shut out the benefits of fresh perspectives.

Another downside to this pair's harmonious connection is the mismatch of resolve. Protagonists love active change, but their firm vision of what must be done might miss the mark. They may simply push their views too strongly for other types to absorb, especially if those friends see a different path for themselves. The inverse is also possible: Diplomat friends can be reluctant – or not willful enough – to push Protagonists beyond their habits and views, preferring to help them feel happy rather than challenge their stability. Either scenario falls short of encouraging beneficial change.

Emotional Transfer

Similarity may also lead Protagonists and their Diplomat friends to unconsciously manipulate each other. They might not try to pull the wool over each other's eyes, but their emotional bond and personal ideals can lead to internal bias. They may confuse their own opinions for their friends' best interests, and both types project their feelings readily. Protagonists can be especially pushy, even if they don't mean

to be. When this happens, criticism or advice may become more about what they want than about what is right for those receiving it. The high level of emotional connection between these friends can make it hard to tell the difference.

Furthermore, Protagonists and Diplomats are naturally sensitive to the emotional states of their friends, so they can be more receptive than most to that kind of influence. If a friend is upset, it's contagious. The way they share emotions is one of the most beautiful, healthy parts of Protagonist–Diplomat friendships, but emotional independence is also a needed skill worth developing. Maintaining personal balance during times of misery, anger, or stress is beneficial for both friends.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Diplomat Friendships

Broadening Their Views Together

Protagonists and their Diplomat friends can break out of any ideological echo chamber by using their gift of asking, "What if...?" out in the wider world. This may mean joining larger groups with more diverse ideas, from book clubs to classes at a community college, or they can find some other way to exit the bubbles that they may inadvertently create together. Protagonists' social natures quickly pave the way for both friends, and in their pursuit of rebalancing a special friendship with each other, these friends will find that including others can be invaluable and exciting.

All Diplomats crave authenticity, so if Protagonists catch a glimpse of worthy qualities outside their immediate realm of familiarity and acceptance, they will explore and ultimately embrace those people. However, they need that glimpse first. Someone with whom they didn't initially feel commonality may have something of value to offer through friendship after all, so they should keep open minds, seeking balance together by widening their scope. They can use these steps to help:

- Agree together to broaden your views and seek the unknown.
- Keep an eye out for different, interesting people.
- Make their acquaintance and engage them socially.

- Discuss together anything learned from others' unfamiliar perspectives.
- Maintain the strength of your own friendship, but try to include others as well.

When both friends work together to engage unusual people who might challenge them, they can reassure each other – not to affirm their limits, but to support each other in expanding them. Who knows what fun will come with different types of friends?

Exercising Independent Thought

Protagonists and Diplomat friends can rebalance subtle manipulations by sharing their feelings and opinions consciously. These friends carry a certain gravity with each other because of the trust inherent in their relationship, but there is a difference between pressure and communication. That may be something that Protagonists, who tend to be forceful, want to fine-tune, especially among Diplomat friends, where emotions abound and harmony is prized. Realizing that influence can take unconscious forms will allow them some awareness when it's happening.

Fortunately, pressure is a betrayal of trust that these sensitive friends find repugnant, and that is the key to rebalancing. Because these friends care so genuinely for each other's well-being, a mere mention of the appearance of any unfair pressure will hit home and likely halt it. When one of these friends takes the time to gently express their concerns, the other can look at their own behavior anew and do whatever it takes to restore balance. It's helpful for these friends to keep these ideas in mind:

- Express criticism as constructive concern, openly and without emotional pressure.
- Don't be afraid to respectfully consider but reject each other's advice while staying firmly on a personal path.
- Try not to get too caught up in each other's emotions. A little distance can enable better objectivity and, ultimately, better care for each other.

It's important for these friends to be supportive, not controlling. Honestly making their opinions known and offering each other help are enough – they don't need to feel responsible for each other's decisions nor take each other's independence as rejection.

Protagonist–Sentinel Friendships

Sentinels are the most reliable and consistent of the types, and Protagonists deeply appreciate those qualities in their friends. Protagonists find their own sincerity mirrored by the scrupulous steadiness of Sentinels, and that provides a foundation for satisfying, long-term friendships. When these two find common ground, fun abounds. This pair may also discover heartfelt inspiration together, as Protagonists' dynamic energy is just as capable of moving mountains as Sentinels' consistency and dedication.

Balanced Protagonist–Sentinel Friendships

Engaging in Life Together

Protagonists explore the boundaries of the possible as a pastime, much of their attention going to hopeful ideals and grand plans that may be hard to bring to fruition. Down-to-earth Sentinels take a more conventional approach that honors the value of procedure. The practical nature of their friendship helps to stabilize Protagonists' imaginative energy. They offer Protagonists joy by bringing grand moments into focus.

Balance goes both ways: Whereas Protagonists are imaginative, their Sentinel friends may be more comfortable with the way things are. This can make them reassuringly dependable to Protagonists, but they may

be more reluctant to engage in exciting opportunities. Protagonists help their Sentinel friends see the benefits of occasionally letting go of limits and exploring fun possibilities together. Both types appreciate a structured approach, so even though one may lean heavily on imagination and the other on tradition, they can plan things in a way that makes them both happy. Protagonists may naturally take the lead in suggesting adventures, but their solid sense of order can make experiences that are outside Sentinels' usual routines seem more comfortable.

Solace and Support

This pair is also well suited to support each other through darker moments. Protagonists' imaginations can be a bottomless pit of worries when negative emotions take over, and they regularly wear themselves down with their endless drive. Sentinels are always ready to provide sensible advice, a plan, and a steady, helping hand to overcome issues real or imagined. Sentinels also sensibly see when it's time to pull Protagonists back from stress and exhaustion into relaxation and fun.

In return, Protagonists not only offer ideas when their Sentinel friends have a problem, they also offer emotional support from the heart. Protagonists can easily tune into their friends' feelings, sympathize with their woes, and respond with a care that soothes their injury and promises brighter days ahead. And of course, once they raise their friends' spirits, this type's brimming energy helps make things better. Sentinels can tap into Protagonists' forthright spirit to regain their own feet and restore happiness.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Sentinel Friendships

Disrupted Rituals

Common values and interests may unite these two initially, but they may proceed in different directions. When Protagonists try to infuse new elements into the friendship (a frequent likelihood), they may find that Sentinels are resistant, preferring to maintain their established pursuits together. This can gradually cause Protagonists to feel bored and Sentinels to be irritated. Their shared Judging trait may grant these

friends some compatibility regarding how they engage in experiences, but it likely won't rectify the differences between their Intuitive and Observant traits.

Protagonists are excited by possibility, always wanting to go out and grab experiences that inspire their imaginations – they seek potential around every corner. Even the most energetic Sentinels, on the other hand, find great satisfaction in happy routines they've created – they're not looking for excitement around every corner because they find such satisfaction in the present. In everyday terms, these friends may gradually spend less time together due to their different ways of finding fun.

Revolution

Similarly, these two may not always agree on what's right to strive for in life. Protagonists are often deeply committed to fighting for their ideals against all odds, even if those ideals are quite abstract. Sentinels, by contrast, are often deeply principled but rarely see the value in producing intangible results – they want to invest in a foundation that's directly related to their daily lives. Protagonists may find it difficult to draw Sentinel friends into their more revolutionary ideas, as people with that personality type are unlikely to be interested in abstract concepts or stretched profundity. As friends, these two may simply not see eye to eye, and when their differences combine with their shared Judging trait, some truly stubborn judgment may surface.

It's not just about how they choose to live their own lives – how they engage in things together can be negatively affected. Even if their personal values and culture are very similar, they may butt heads on everyday matters of idealism versus practicality, with Protagonists zealously demanding what they think is right and Sentinels insisting on what they see as realistic. Sentinels have little patience for what they see as wasted effort, and Protagonists bristle against limits – so these friends can easily frustrate each other.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Sentinel Friendships

Fun Together

One step toward closing the gap between Protagonists' conceptual focus

and Sentinels' fixed, practical view is to approach that difference with a sense of acceptance and mutual respect. Sentinels and Protagonists value the well-being of other people, especially close friends. This common ground bodes well for nurturing their friendships. Sentinels can ask their Protagonist friends to take a deep breath when they're flush with a new idea or passion, and Protagonists can invite their Sentinel friends into new experiences without pushing them too hard.

Understanding is only the first step – both friends can also work to recapture and expand mutual interests. Something drew these two together in the first place, and focusing on finding similar things to do together will reaffirm the friendship. With their imaginations and bold energy, Protagonists should have little trouble thinking up new ways to approach a favorite shared subject.

Both friends can also accord each other a little leeway. Rather than holding stubbornly to personal preferences all the time, true friends find happiness by seeing each other's joy. To help resolve their different ideas into good times together, these friends can:

- Identify one area of commonality (for example, you met in art class and both love art).
- Talk about new ways to share the subject together – make a list of ideas.
- Review the ideas in terms of preference, and identify ideas with the most commonality. (Perhaps one friend wants to fly to New York and tour art galleries, and the other would rather stay home and experiment with new sculpture techniques together, but both agree on a fun road trip to visit in-state galleries and sculpture gardens.)
- Engage with the most mutual activities first, and work up to more significant compromises. Neither should feel pressured or obligated, but both can consider stepping out of their comfort zones for a friend.
- Try one of the fun activities together on a regular schedule. Once per week or once per month – it doesn't matter, if the plan works for both friends and they commit to having fun together.

Although they can be stubborn, both types also firmly believe in being caring. Compromising on their own desires sometimes is a great way to show that principle in action.

Using the Benefits of Differences

Protagonists' visionary flights of mind may not make much sense even to their closest Sentinel friends, who simply aren't prone to them. However, it's precisely this dynamic that can create a healthy counterbalance between the two. The key isn't so much in compromising their very different approaches – future versus present, imagination versus practicality – but rather offering their unique and valuable perspectives in service of each other's goals.

When Protagonists see that their Sentinel friends are trying to accomplish something, whether light or serious, they can offer their imaginative take and dauntless energy to help achieve that goal. They are powerful allies, and bending an unconventional approach to suit a conventional end – or vice versa – is a great way for these friends to appreciate each other. Sentinels can, in turn, offer their grounded, steady efforts to help Protagonists work toward their goals, no matter how idealistic or even unrealistic they may seem.

Even if such dreams are out of reach, Protagonists will never forget that their Sentinel friends stood by them – the support affirms their bond and is deeply meaningful to Protagonists. And Sentinels may be surprised at just how attainable dreams can be with enough hope and effort shared between good friends. Both friends can consider the following:

- Invite each other into a personal goal, whether recreational or not. (For example, a Protagonist friend may be trying to create a local disc-golf league, and a Sentinel may want to build an organic garden.)
- Spend a little time each week helping each other with whatever ideas, discussions, and direct help feels comfortable. Keep it fun and light.
- Remember that Sentinels' studious approach and Protagonists' outgoing social nature can provide balance. For example, the

Sentinel might help the Protagonist tear through the tedium of creating and distributing flyers and posting on social media, and the Protagonist might provide energetic company during tours of organic agriculture facilities in the area.

- Try to be open to each other's ideas, and at least try them out.
- Contribute unique ideas and approaches freely, but respect your friend's choices about their own goals, and let them lead. If cheerful company and an extra set of hands are the only contributions, that's still a win.
- Throughout the process, be aware of the unique advantages of each other's approaches and methods. This is a chance to learn while having fun with a friend.

Even though Protagonists and Sentinels may sometimes be caught off-guard by the different ways that they approach the world, helping each other with even casual goals can go a long way toward creating shared understanding and joy.

Protagonist–Explorer Friendships

Possibly one of the most interesting combinations of friends, Protagonists and Explorers can find wonderful adventures together, and they may even enlighten each other. Explorers are more adaptable than idealistic – highly pragmatic, they rarely relate to the philosophical goals typical of Protagonists. Protagonists embrace long-term dedication like a badge of honor, whereas Explorers nimbly adapt to suit circumstances, comfortable with spontaneity and often immersed in the moment to the exclusion of all else. Even though it is a seemingly odd pairing, any mutual passion can quickly kindle a dynamic and inspired friendship.

Balanced Protagonist–Explorer Friendships

Learning from Each Other's Views

Protagonist–Explorer friendships offer both people wonderful opportunities to grow. Protagonists can act as humanistic compasses for their Explorer friends by reminding them of interconnected aspects of life, offering encouraging examples of how to focus on personal goals while still considering a greater good. For novelty-seeking Explorers, exploring the altruistic stimulates their sense of adventure, which is especially fun if it involves working on a tangible project with rapid payoff.

Protagonists inspire Explorers to think more widely when they become too intent on themselves, and Explorers center Protagonists who've lost touch with themselves in their fervent pursuit of idealistic goals. Protagonists love to have fun, but they can also be very serious, perhaps excessively. Determined ideas can dominate their thinking – although laudable, their determination can bring stress, especially when it pits them against other people.

Explorers are perfectly suited to bringing Protagonists out of their heads and into the moment. The immediacy and often self-gratifying bent of Explorers' outlook can offer a needed break for Protagonists caught up in their intense thoughts. Explorers cheerfully encourage them to relax and have fun, to stop and smell the roses as they charge up the road of destiny.

Exploring the Unknown Together

In a way, both Protagonists and Explorers enjoy unconventional approaches to life: Protagonists are warriors at heart, pushing for change in line with their beliefs and always ready to challenge restrictive authority. In a similar vein, Explorers place novelty and self-determination above all, disregarding rules and conventions in favor of their own passions, quick to defy (or ignore) anyone who tries to restrict them. Both are revolutionaries, in a way. This common ground provides opportunities for them to stretch boundaries and gain something excitingly different through their friendship.

Explorers love to take on new things by getting involved, and although Protagonists may be a little more reserved when it comes to unexpected

changes, they leap into experiences that capture their interest. This is a recipe for good times and discoveries together: festivals, surfing, wine tasting, camping, pottery classes – they'll happily share any enriching activities. With Explorers' openness to opportunity and Protagonists' willful imagination, these friends can share endless adventures.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Explorer Friendships

Loose Spontaneity Clashing with Firm Dedication

Unfortunately, the ability of these types to connect through exciting pursuits doesn't always extend to the fundamental ways that they engage in life. Protagonists are planners who follow through on their goals with lively energy. Explorers, on the other hand, find little use in confining themselves to a preconceived track – they constantly adjust not only their approach but also their direction. When they feel uncomfortable committing, it's not because they won't follow through or don't care about a friend, but rather because formalizing things can turn joys into obligations.

In a friendship, this subtle but powerful difference can come to the fore often, whether they're going out for coffee, planning a trip, or helping each other with projects. When Protagonists place expectations of consistency on free-wheeling Explorers, they end up disappointed. In turn, Explorers get irritated when Protagonists try to "keep them on track," experiencing such intervention as a limitation. Without some allowance and understanding, these friends may rile each other even when attempting to carry out fun activities together.

Don't Judge Me!

Core differences can also affect how these friends gauge actions, personal interests, and values. Protagonists sometimes overreach with their principled intentions, pushing their views on others. Explorers, in contrast, maintain a "live and let live" attitude, far more tolerant of other people's differing views – they would rather not get involved with things that they don't feel affect them. Protagonists are all about getting involved though, rarely tolerant of anything they don't agree with. Explorers may criticize such interventions as unnecessary, foolish, even meddlesome, especially when they are aimed at them.

Explorers are often quick to act on desires without much thought for future consequences. In the grip of excitement, they tend to resent anyone who tries to make them think twice about their decisions. Undaunted when they feel they are acting on behalf of a friend, Protagonists may take their genuine concern too far, so that it comes across as sanctimonious judgment. Explorers rebel wildly against this, regardless of the intent behind it. The fastest way to lose such a friend is to try and control them, but Protagonists have a very hard time allowing what they think is wrong, especially if they feel a friend may be at risk.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Explorer Friendships

Committing to Fun

Both types can reconcile differing preferences by focusing on their appreciation for each other. Protagonists can tap into their own bright-eyed enthusiasm for the future and embrace a sense of fun as Explorers pull them out of their routine and place them in the moment, where imagination and vigorous engagement – qualities that Protagonists possess in abundance – are free to reign. Instead of resenting sudden changes, Protagonists can focus on the friend they're with, knowing that cheerfully engaging the unexpected brings rewards of kinship and fun.

In addition to practicing some flexibility, Protagonists should be clear about how much their commitments and values mean to them. Although spontaneity may be thrilling, and Protagonists can handle change, sudden shifts sometimes leave them feeling disappointed and stressed. Explorers care about their friends, so Protagonists should share such feelings to ensure a balanced friendship. The following steps can help:

- Agree whether time together will be loose or structured. A fun day of shopping is an opportunity for spontaneity, but a concert is an appropriate time for friends to stick to a plan.
- If commitment is difficult, say so up front. There's nothing wrong with respectfully keeping options open.
- Don't cancel plans with each other without notice and a good reason.

- When enjoying unstructured time together:
  - Pick a starting point together but then let things blossom as they will.
  - Go with the flow and cheerfully accept each other's spontaneous ideas.
  - Focus on each other as much as the activity. Fun can be created between good friends regardless of what they're doing.
  - Remember that any plan to "hang out" is still a promise to a friend.
- When enjoying a planned activity together:
  - Decide together on an activity or outing.
  - Agree on a time, then show up on schedule.
  - Stick with each other as planned.

If having something "their way" means the other friend isn't having any fun, either person can consider relaxing their own preferences for the sake of a friend.

Respecting Each Other's Focus

Protagonists may not want to hear about the latest upgrades to an engine that their Explorer friends are raving about. Explorers may want to shrug off a conversation about how producing the hamburger they're eating uses the same amount of water as a three-hour shower. However, good friends can suspend their disinterest to show appreciation for each other. Protagonists may seem to drone on about the state of the world, and Explorers just want to get their hands on that engine, but if Explorers ask questions about the water crisis and Protagonists ask for an explanation of the engine upgrades, both friends might be surprised by how satisfying shared enthusiasm can be.

Protagonists and Explorers can also choose to go along for the ride occasionally, setting aside their own preferences temporarily. Friendship is a participatory sport: If friends are rigid and disinterested in what excites each other, their friendships will rest on an unstable

foundation. Each friend may have to take a step outside their comfort zone to share good times together. When one friend does so, the other can make sure that they show their appreciation for the respectful gesture, which reaffirms and sustains the friendship itself. Some suggestions both friends can use:

- Ask to be invited into something your friend holds dear – it may be an explanatory conversation or an involved experience.
- Let your friend set the format for sharing their interest.
- Ask questions about what your friend gets out of it. Try to understand their passion.
- Act like a polite guest, and don't criticize their interest while trying it out.
- Express bright appreciation for any little aspect that seems inspiring or laudable – play up the positives.
- Discuss the experience afterward over coffee or a meal.
- Consider inviting your friend into one of your personal interests next time.

These friends can enjoy discovering what makes each other tick without marching to the beat of the same drum. They may discover new ways to have fun together, as enthusiasm can be infectious among good friends.

Conclusion

Finding Unexpected Strength in Others

Protagonists can spread and share in great joy by offering their amazing qualities to any type through friendship. What remains for each Protagonist to decide is whether they can be equally open to finding fulfillment and rewards in friendships with different types of people. Protagonists excel at fostering positive change. When they also master the ability to honor and appreciate others for simply being who they are, even if it represents something that departs from their own lifestyle, they open doors to unexpected friendships that can change them for the better.

For some types, fun and laughter are enough to sustain lasting friendship. But for Protagonists, a friend is someone they can hold close to their heart, who not only offers them merriment and companionship but also dares to inspire them beyond their own limits. For this type, friendship is about a meeting of the minds and a solid, reliable bond. As strong-willed, naturally social leaders, Protagonists benefit from friends who have an equally strong sense of self, who can stand up to their assumptions and give them guidance. Such friends become lifelong companions during happy times and fun adventures, as well as sources of support when they realize that they need to lean on someone they can trust.

Romantic Relationships

Depth and Dedication

Warm, caring, and capable of unconditional love, Protagonists can reach a level of depth in their relationships that most people only dream of. People with this personality type take romance seriously, approaching it with true dedication and passion. Even early in dating, Protagonists are willing to put in serious time and effort to foster their relationships. They do everything in their power to encourage their partners' growth and success, and their dream is to fall in love with someone who supports their own growth in return. Although they can be picky, Protagonists crave romantic connection, and when they find someone that they truly respect, they aren't afraid to commit.

Protagonists' relationships are founded on generosity, dedication, and emotional honesty. Curious and perceptive, Protagonists can often detect subtle changes in their partners, to the extent that they might seem to read minds. That said, people of this type aren't afraid to ask outright how their partners feel about the relationship. If status checks don't become too frequent or overbearing, they can help Protagonists and their partners identify and resolve potential issues rather than letting them fester.

Due to this extraordinary level of emotional investment, breakups can trigger a tremendous sense of guilt and betrayal in Protagonists – even after relatively short relationships. When this happens, it's often because Protagonists have become invested in the *idea* of the relationship in addition to the reality. They may have lost sight of the person in front of them, focusing instead on their visions of how they

and a partner could develop together. As they grow, people with this personality type must learn to distinguish between idealizations of their romantic future and the refuge of true love.

Going Deep

Whether early in the dating process or later in a relationship, Protagonists aren't satisfied by small talk. What interests them are ideas and beliefs, goals, and dreams. When romantic partners won't communicate at that level, people with this personality type quickly lose interest.

Like many people with the Intuitive trait, Protagonists don't believe in "leaving well enough alone." Instead, they want their relationships, and the people in them, to grow. They look for ways to improve their connections and deepen their love, and they expect their partners to do the same rather than settling for the status quo. Although this relentless desire to grow can sometimes be irritating, it motivates Protagonists to bring their best selves – sincere, earnest, and caring – to their relationships.

On a Pedestal

Ultimately, Protagonists want to find a soul mate. Whereas Analysts crave intellectual stimulation, Explorers seek fun, and Sentinels cherish stability, people with this personality type are looking for something else: a connection at the deepest level. When they feel that level of connection, Protagonists' dedication and passion are nothing short of remarkable. If left unchecked, however, their romantic idealism can go into overdrive, leading them to value a partner's *potential* – to grow into a kinder, deeper, more self-actualized person – rather than the actual person by their side.

Alas, this is rarely the recipe for an equitable relationship. Protagonists may push their partners to change, becoming frustrated when their partners don't work (or seem to work) to improve themselves. However well intended, this behavior can make their partners feel judged, pushed around, or resentful. Unless Protagonists respect their partners' willingness – or lack thereof – to change, they risk driving a wedge between themselves and the person they love.

Potential Pairings by Role

Cultivating a satisfying relationship isn't always easy, especially for a type so concerned with depth and authenticity. Whether in romantic partnerships or other aspects of their lives, Protagonists won't settle for the status quo at the expense of growth and discovery. As a result, they aren't content with partnerships that – however comfortable or convenient – don't move them at a deep level.

Fortunately, every personality type has something to contribute, and as Protagonists date and pursue long-term relationships, they find many opportunities for meaningful connections. This section explains common patterns in relationships between Protagonists and each of the different role groups – Analysts, other Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. By understanding such patterns, people with this personality type can approach their romantic lives with awareness, insight, and compassion, maximizing their chances of finding and sustaining meaningful, loving partnerships.

Protagonist–Analyst Relationships

Comfortable with ideas and abstractions, Protagonists and Analysts share a visionary, open-minded view of the world. Despite their shared interest in creativity and inspiration, they aren't identical – in this relationship, each partner offers strengths and capabilities that don't come naturally to the other. Whereas Protagonists enjoy profound human insight, Analysts excel at improving systems and assessing situations objectively. As time progresses, their differing perspectives can enable Protagonists and Analysts to balance each other's weaknesses and bring out the best in each other, creating vital bonds of mutual respect and trust.

Balanced Protagonist–Analyst Relationships

Deep Thinkers

Like Protagonists, Analysts love bold, original thinking. Neither has much patience for small talk – they want to go deep. Some people might say, "We don't discuss religion or politics at the dinner table," but these Intuitive types might both respond, "Then what is there to talk about?" Protagonists delve into the human side of issues, and Analysts push for thorough, logical understanding. When they value their differing perspectives as complementary rather than incompatible, the result is lively, meaningful conversation.

Given their creative, imaginative minds, these types find endless subjects to discuss. Topics that combine technology and human progress – for example, using social media to apply pressure to oppressive regimes or corrupt institutions – can keep these types talking for months, as can more personal discussions about goals and dreams. Far from fleeting chitchat, these conversations reignite the sparks between Protagonists and Analysts, fostering respect, affection, and mutual curiosity even as the relationship progresses.

Emotion and Rationality

Protagonists bring warmth and emotion to their relationships – qualities that Analysts often struggle to show. Leading by example, Protagonists help their partners better understand not just sensitivity and romance, but also the value of human connection on a deeper level. With Protagonists' help, Analysts reap the rewards of an emotional attunement that transcends the limitations of pure logic.

In turn, Protagonists are often amazed by their Analyst partners' ability to wrangle with big ideas in a rational way. In healthy relationships, Analysts offer reasoned, thoughtful stances on difficult, complex decisions, from which house to buy to whether to move across the world. Unlike some other types, however, Analysts can offer logical viewpoints without curtailing a shared sense of progress and possibility. The result is a beautiful counterpoint to Protagonists' idealistic – and at times unrealistic – fervor.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Analyst Relationships

Routine Roulette

Despite their facility with grand visions and big ideas, Protagonist–Analyst couples can falter in the face of everyday routines. These types encourage each other's grand aspirations, which is beautiful – unless it prevents them from managing their shared responsibilities. Such issues may not be evident early in a relationship, when these two revel in novelty and possibility. In fact, newly partnered Protagonists and Analysts might roll their eyes at couples who create chore charts or devote their weekends to running errands.

If these two move in together, however, the demands of everyday life can trigger a surprising amount of stress. Simple tasks such as taking out the trash, paying bills, and stocking the fridge create tension and disagreement if no one routinely handles them. Unless these partners temper their big-picture perspectives with a willingness to take care of necessities, the resulting accumulation of neglected chores can compromise not only their grand plans but also their equanimity.

The Head and the Heart

Protagonists lead from the heart, and they appreciate romantic gestures – whether in the form of flowers on Valentine's Day or long, sentimental messages in greeting cards. Alas, many Analysts see such gestures as pointless. Why spend money on a bouquet of flowers that will wither within days?

During the dating stage, Analyst partners might successfully "fake" some of the sentimental rituals of courtship. Soon enough, however, Protagonists may detect when a gesture doesn't come from the heart, and they may feel disappointed, much to Analysts' chagrin. When Analysts perform a romantic gesture, it is solely to make a partner happy – if they've gone through the motions of buying flowers, they expect their partner to feel pleased, not disappointed. This gap might seem like a superficial obstacle, but demonstrations of emotional support and connection mean a great deal to Protagonists – something that Analysts may struggle to understand.

This dynamic can manifest in many areas of life. After a hard, draining day, Protagonists want their partners to listen, validate their feelings,

and empathize with them, whereas Analysts might rush in to suggest logical solutions. Faced with an onslaught of suggestions, Protagonists may feel as if they're being invalidated or even criticized for not pursuing solutions that seem obvious to their Analyst partners. Even though Analysts are trying to help, their default is to approach issues with their heads rather than their hearts, and sensitive Protagonists may feel hurt as a result.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Analyst Relationships

The Dreaded Chore Chart

On the practical front, Protagonist–Analyst couples should address chores and responsibilities head-on. If they ignore their to-do lists for too long – or put off making to-do lists altogether – they will find themselves mired in unnecessary stress, which inevitably takes its toll on the relationship. Something as trivial as having nothing to cook for dinner can trigger an argument at the end of a long day.

Fortunately, this couple doesn't have to spend all their free time on chores, nor should they. Instead, they can create calendar reminders for recurring tasks, such as picking up groceries; establish automatic bill payments; or outsource certain tasks, such as lawn maintenance or home cleaning, if resources permit.

The couple may also want to avoid taking on too many projects or products that require routine maintenance, from "fixer-upper" houses to additional cars. Keeping life simple is the name of the game. By minimizing the number of claims on their time and attention, they free up time to learn and grow together. Some suggestions to do so:

- Set aside a time to discuss household responsibilities – an hour should suffice. (The process is more pleasant with snacks.)
- Discuss each partner's vision for a well-run, well-maintained life. How clean must the house or apartment be? How often must laundry be done?
- List every recurring chore, sorting them into the following categories: finances, cleaning and laundry, home maintenance,

shopping and errands, and miscellaneous. If relevant, add child care, yard maintenance, car maintenance, and any responsibilities unique to your shared lifestyle.

- Circle every item that can be automated, such as paying bills or setting aside a certain amount of money from each paycheck for retirement. Decide which partner will set up these automations and mutually determine a deadline for doing so. If possible, tackle the tasks in the moment, while the inspiration to do so is fresh.
- Cross out sources of "chore stress" that can be eliminated, such as underused tools, unworn clothes, or unloved clutter that just fills up the cabinets and accumulates dust. Plan how to dispose of the items appropriately.
- Divide the remaining tasks, mutually agreeing on who will take care of what and how frequently. Set aside some chores to do together, and find ways to make them relatively enjoyable – such as putting on music or pairing a trip to the hardware store with a visit to a pizza parlor.
- Every week, revisit the list and decide which tasks will be prioritized for the days ahead. Schedule time to take care of them.

When dividing chores, partners can volunteer to take on more responsibility in areas that suit them. Protagonists might feel drawn to teacher conferences, whereas Analysts might enjoy tackling more technical areas such as auto or bicycle maintenance.

Getting Support

Analysts genuinely want to support their Protagonist partners. By default, they offer suggestions and solutions rather than empathy and romantic gestures. Like any type, Analysts hate to see the people they love in pain, and that feeling compels them to jump in with ideas when their partner has had a bad day. Unfortunately, Protagonists might not be able to detect the good intentions beneath Analysts' "Why don't you just..." – particularly when they're already feeling hurt or vulnerable and looking for sympathy. The result is hurt feelings on both sides, even though Analysts might not let on that it bothers them when their well-meant suggestions are cast aside.

To bridge this divide, Protagonists may need to consciously remind themselves that their partners just want them to be happy. It's possible to misinterpret Analysts' communication style as judgmental or uncaring even when they're trying to be helpful, as these types aren't fluent in the warm expressions and compassionate gestures that come so naturally to Protagonists. When Protagonists want support, they may have to specify their exact needs rather than expect their Analyst partners to know how to soothe them. The following tips may help:

- Ask for a listening ear. Clarify your needs: "I just had the worst argument with my sister, and I need to get it off my chest." This clarifies that the goal of the conversation is an improved mental or emotional state, not a solution or an action plan.
- If your Analyst partner interrupts with suggestions, respond by saying, "I'm so grateful that you want to help. I'll only feel worse if this conversation becomes a to-do list. Can we save the problem-solving for another time?" Or "Right now I just want to talk it through. Figuring out what to do can come later." Analysts respect this kind of independence.
- Offer thanks and appreciation for your Analyst partner's time and care. Analysts aren't emotional mind readers, so explain how their presence and support – and restraint – have been helpful and meaningful.

By modifying their communication style, Protagonists can create conditions that allow their Analyst partners to offer sincere care. Even when Analysts do step in with suggestions rather than empathy, Protagonists can recognize and appreciate the ways that they show they care. By recognizing the loving energy that motivates Analysts' behavior, Protagonists can find emotional healing in even their partners' most practical contributions.

Protagonist–Diplomat Relationships

Protagonists and their Diplomat partners inspire each other's imaginations. These two find common ground naturally thanks to shared values, including compassion and self-development. They are also poised to understand and appreciate each other's creative pursuits, passions, and dreams. Together, Protagonists and Diplomats can foster a beautifully supportive relationship, with each partner validating aspects of the other's personality that much of the world would dismiss as overly idealistic or impractical.

Balanced Protagonist–Diplomat Relationships

The Beauty of Their Dreams

Diplomats are exceptionally attuned to others' thoughts and emotions, which can be a blessing, but it also means that they are acutely sensitive to slights – or even perceived slights – from other people. As a result, they may hesitate to share their innermost longings with people who seem to value efficiency, security, or adrenaline rushes over the magic of art or the thrill of true human connection.

Therefore, in the early stages of a relationship between a Protagonist and another Diplomat, the two are likely over the moon to *finally* find someone who seems to understand their life philosophy. These two understand each other's sensitivities, so they know how to encourage rather than stifle each other's seeds of dreams – whether writing a novel, founding a nonprofit, or living overseas. Sharing their desires with each other can be a cathartic, profoundly validating experience, one that transforms the bonds of attraction and affection into something more enduring.

As the relationship matures, Protagonists and Diplomats can gently encourage each other to follow through on their longings rather than doubt them or let them languish in the idea phase. Although execution may not come naturally to these two, they blossom in the presence of people who believe in them. By admiring and encouraging each other's aspirations, Protagonists and Diplomats can remind one another of the beauty of their dreams. In this way, they not only support each other's growth but also grow closer as a couple.

Compassion and Communion

A sense of unity grows quickly in Protagonist–Diplomat relationships. Over time, unity develops into subtle intensity and loyalty that may not be visible to outsiders but is felt deeply between the partners. The source of their connection is the couple's exceptional compassion, which motivates them to understand and accommodate each other at a profound level.

Early in a relationship, this understanding may be shallower than either partner realizes. What is remarkable about this couple, however, is that as they get to know each other better, their appreciation often increases. They see growth as a virtue, accepting their partners as nuanced human beings – beautiful as they are and yet works in progress. By creating an environment where each partner feels seen, heard, and accepted, these two can enjoy a connection that is founded on a deep desire for understanding. This is a relationship in which each person feels free to inhabit their authentic selves – especially vital for Diplomats.

Dream It, Do It

Among Diplomats, Protagonists are relatively action oriented. Sure, they can spend hours (or weeks) dreaming up visions for a better future, but they also care about taking steps to turn their dreams into reality. This is a wonderful strength to contribute to a Diplomat–Diplomat relationship, as other Diplomats may struggle to act on their grand ideas. Together, Protagonist–Diplomat couples can look beyond the status quo and recognize potential and possibility where others don't see it. And thanks to Protagonists' influence, they can bridge the gap between dreaming and taking action.

In turn, other types of Diplomats can help Protagonists slow down and take a break. Protagonists are nothing if not driven, and although this trait makes them effective, it can also lead to exhaustion, burnout, and wasted energy. Other Diplomats offer a beautiful counterpoint, gently encouraging Protagonists to take a day off from their missions and engagements every now and again. Downtime can renew a couple's sense of connection, allowing them to set aside time and energy to deepen their intellectual, emotional, and physical intimacy.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Diplomat Relationships

Too Much

If Protagonists don't balance their individual needs with the needs of the relationship, a deep connection can be subsumed by an overwhelming sense of enmeshment. Too much togetherness with Diplomat partners can feel stifling, particularly if it prevents Protagonists from pursuing their individual interests and developing their own views and opinions. As they pursue their personal goals for self-development, Protagonists need the space and latitude to set aside others' expectations and be their true selves.

Likewise, they expect their partners to chart their own courses for self-development. When partners fail to do so – or rather, when they don't conform to Protagonists' vision of what it means to pursue self-development – Protagonists may become restless and impatient. Gradually they can lose respect, wondering why their partners can't be more independent, autonomous, or self-possessed. Alas, Diplomats will almost certainly pick up on such judgments, reducing trust and intimacy in the relationship. This can become a vicious cycle, with sensitive Diplomat partners engaging in clingy, needy, or codependent behavior in a decidedly unproductive effort to regain Protagonists' approval.

White Knights

Protagonist–Diplomat couples may struggle with their idealistic expectations about relationships. In the dating phase, they might interpret shared interests and surprisingly honest conversations – about their lives, their hopes, and the hardships they've faced – as stand-ins

for compatibility and connection. They may even place each other on pedestals, romanticizing and idealizing their relationship before it has truly begun. Alas, just as no person is perfect, no relationship is either. All couples experience conflict, and lasting connection requires awareness, effort, and daily commitment. Most importantly, true happiness can't be found in another person.

This reality can be uncomfortable for any Protagonists and Diplomats who expect another person to "complete them" or who expect a relationship to salve their emotional wounds. In the early days of a relationship, things may indeed seem perfect. But over time, issues inevitably arise – and not just in the form of disagreements (although those are also inevitable). One person might lose a parent or experience a significant setback at work and be dismayed to find that the other partner's love and compassion can't heal their grief or relieve their stress. Protagonists in particular may feel let down if they believe that their partners aren't taking clear actions to offer support. When their partner doesn't protect them from emotional or existential pain, they may call the relationship itself into question as a result.

Unfinished Business

On a more practical level, life organization may pose a problem for Protagonists with Diplomat partners, even if other aspects of their shared lives seem ideal. Thanks to their Intuitive and Feeling traits, these couples feel drawn to big ideas and dreams about the future. Paying the electric bill, maintaining a budget, or completing the final stages of a home improvement project can slip right off their radar.

As a result, these two may sail along smoothly when their main worry is fostering their new relationship, but when they move in together, couple their finances, and share domestic responsibilities, the pressure can mount. Whose responsibility is it to take out the recycling? How much debt is accumulating on the credit card? When was the car supposed to get an oil change again? Faced with these common challenges, the couple may feel overwhelmed, retreating deeper into procrastination – which only triggers more anxiety and tension in the long run.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Diplomat Relationships

Space and Time

Protagonist–Diplomat couples, with their constant focus on each other's feelings, sometimes forget that they don't need to spend every moment together, nor do they have to step in and help whenever their partner feels down. Emotions come in waves, and sometimes people do best when allowed to process and release their feelings on their own. These partners, like all couples, occasionally need to offer each other space and take time to themselves.

If two people pursue different hobbies, disagree on certain topics, or process some of their issues on their own, it doesn't mean that the relationship is doomed. In fact, moments of independence foster a more sustainable bond between partners, allowing them to enjoy a meaningful connection without being subsumed by it. That said, Diplomats might (understandably) take it personally if their partner suggests spending more time apart. It's best to initiate such changes casually and agreeably, not within the context of a fight or argument. Here are some suggestions toward that end:

- Announce the change in a cheerful, good-natured way, taking care not to say anything that could be interpreted as critical.
- If possible, suggest a joint activity for another time: "I'm going to the park for the pickup basketball game. Want to get dinner together afterward?"
- Frame the change as an opportunity for mutual support. After all, time apart can benefit both partners: Introverted partners get the gift of alone time to curl up with a good book or contemplate the world, and Extraverted partners can cultivate their own friendships and connections.
- If tension or resistance arises, defuse it by explaining the emotional and mental benefits of meeting new people and getting into a group. "Playing basketball used to make me feel so strong and confident, and I'd really like to make some new friends in the neighborhood." Diplomats want to help, and if they understand the benefit of allowing their partners more space, they'll be motivated to do it.

Both Protagonists and their Diplomat partners can find opportunities to communicate that they need their space without it feeling like a rejection. Protagonists can also temper their expectations with appreciation, recognizing how rare it is to find a partner who wants to help them as much as a Diplomat does.

No Airbrushing

Relationships may seem to be the answer to everything. Gorgeous, courageous, and smart, our partners sweep us off our feet, see the inner beauty that others missed, and make our hearts whole again. They comfort us when we're sad, provide for us when we're broke, and make every day into a waking adventure. It's like that line from *Jerry Maguire*: "You complete me."

Yes, we can roll our eyes at these over-the-top idealizations, but thanks to advertising, social media, and perhaps even the people in our lives, these dreams linger in our unconscious minds. The result is a black-and-white dynamic where either we've found our perfect match or we haven't. Protagonists and other Diplomats can be especially susceptible to this type of thinking, mentally "airbrushing" their partners and indulging in unrealistic expectations. Then, when their partners – inevitably – let them down, these types might call an entire relationship into question.

To combat this phenomenon, Protagonists can start by acknowledging their own missteps, weaknesses, and personal difficulties in a healthy, balanced way. This fosters a sense of safety and openness in the relationship, allowing partners to cultivate true empathy and respect for each other.

- When appropriate, acknowledge mistakes and personal struggles – without fishing for validation or going overboard.
- Don't expect reciprocation (in other words, your Diplomat partner immediately acknowledging their own weaknesses). Instead, view this as an opportunity to increase the honesty, depth, and realness of the relationship – a time for both partners to release the need to be (or appear to be) perfect.
- Notice how your Diplomat partner conveys support, encouragement, and acceptance.

- In time, when your Diplomat partner expresses their own weaknesses, mirror the support that they offered to you in the past.
- Remember that these areas for growth are part of the human condition, and as such, they allow us to feel true empathy toward one another.

Expressions of vulnerability open a space for both partners to be honest and real rather than defensive or judgmental. No one is perfect, and by acknowledging this in a balanced, nonjudgmental way, we create relationships where empathy and authenticity can thrive.

Procrastination Begone

When this couple senses a lack of connection with each other, the issue may have surprisingly tangible roots. Even for these big-picture thinkers, heaps of unopened mail, half-finished home-improvement projects, and overflowing trash cans create stress. Add in some tension over who should do what, and there's a recipe for a frazzled, disconnected couple.

Protagonists can actively encourage their Diplomat partners – and themselves – to attend to practical matters. Deep, meaningful conversations can be immensely rewarding, but sometimes it's necessary to sit down and pay the bills. These partners may be more focused on higher personal goals than laundry, but by forming an understanding and following through, they can support each other's attention to mundane responsibilities. Here are some steps to address the issue:

- Set aside an hour or two. Sit together in a comfortable place with a notebook and pen.
- Have each partner envision and share how they would feel and what they would do without the weight of unfinished business hanging over them. Jot down notes.
    - Would they feel more inspired to create?
    - Would it be easier for them to access their craft supplies?
- Commit to tackling unfinished business as a team. Maybe even create a team name, if it's motivational.

- Create an informal accountability agreement, a promise between partners to help with chores and old to-do items so that both can enjoy a happier, more relaxing life together. Have each partner voice a promise.
- List each item of unfinished business, from washing the dirty dishes in the sink to calling the roofer for an estimate.
- Decide who will be responsible for each item and when they will take care of it. Prioritize essential tasks (paying bills) over somewhat optional ones (weeding the garden).
    - Don't overcommit.
    - Automate recurring items whenever possible.
    - Commit to revisiting this list at the same time every week and adjusting it as necessary – with practice, the process will become quicker and easier.
- Stick to the plan.
    - Thank each other for contributions.
    - Regularly revisit the notes from step two.
    - Reconnect to this spirit of working together to create a better future.
- When possible, tackle chores as a team. Doing the dishes together can transform a tedious chore into a chance to bump shoulders and laugh.

Clearing away a list of old chores can be remarkably refreshing, and this couple may find that with their kitchen clean and their bills settled, they suddenly feel freer to live the lives that they want, whether planting the seeds of a new endeavor or by enjoying the fruits of their hard work.

Protagonist–Sentinel Relationships

Protagonists and Sentinels find common ground in their drive to help others. Sentinels do this by creating and preserving stability, ensuring that the ground is firm beneath their loved ones' feet. Protagonists foster values and offer emotional support, aiming to make the world beautiful and just for those they love. Together, this couple can enjoy the incredible satisfaction that comes from mutual support and wholehearted living.

Balanced Protagonist–Sentinel Relationships

Dedication and Good Sense

Although Protagonists might not always want to keep their feet on the ground, they may come to appreciate the order and structure that Sentinels bring to a relationship. Beneath their romantic longings, Protagonists crave someone dependable and steadfast, someone who can weather storms by their side. Sentinels can fit this bill beautifully – they view loyalty as essential to a balanced relationship and commit fully once they find the right person.

By drawing on each other's strengths, this couple can balance the comfort of constancy with the challenge (and delight) of necessary change. Although they value the status quo, Sentinels are hardly intent on discouraging their partners – in fact, they can serve as great sounding boards, helping Protagonists distinguish inspiration from fantasy. Whether Protagonists long to take a road trip across the United States or start an animal shelter, they can count on Sentinels' good sense and practical clarity. This couple functions best when they strive

to appreciate each other's dreams and goals – they can accomplish this by looking for common ground, rather than differences, in envisioning a good life.

Inspiration and Execution

Protagonists may be pleasantly surprised to find that their imagination and idealism are attractive to pragmatic-minded Sentinels. Even Sentinels can enjoy broadening their comfort zones and discovering new delights, and Protagonists love to step in and share the things that matter to them, from music to mountain vistas. Although such gestures might seem small from the outside, they can become part of the couple's shared identity, reinforcing their appreciation for each other and renewing their curiosity about each other's opinions, ideas, and viewpoints.

When Protagonists balance their unabashed revolutionary voice with love and respect, Sentinels feel welcome to expand their thinking and consider new perspectives. Protagonists bring a breath of fresh air to the staid mentality of some Sentinels, infusing their interactions with hope, encouragement, and energy. With Protagonist partners, Sentinels think bigger than they might on their own, while bringing in the grounded attention necessary to see whether the details really can line up. Together, this couple can enjoy all the phases of life together, with Protagonists delighting in sharing new things with their partners and Sentinels gratified by the opportunity to provide stability and continuity when it's needed the most.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Sentinel Relationships

Mistaking What's Practical

Once the novelty of inspiration wears off, Protagonists may find their Sentinel partners questioning the practicality of their ideas. When Protagonists launch into yet another notion on how to better the future or rearrange the world, their Sentinel partners might groan, "Enough already." Sentinels may mistake Protagonists' multitude of interests and involvements as shallowness or disorganization. This can undermine Protagonists' vision of themselves as capable and effective.

The difference between what's practical and what's not is often a matter of opinion. Sentinels live by fixed rules and traditions, and they organize the world around them in common-sense, day-to-day ways. Protagonists' creativity and lofty imagination may seem immature or impractical to them, especially when Protagonists challenge rules or goals that Sentinels see as necessary. If both partners insist on being right, their differences of opinion can trigger significant imbalances, eroding the respect and goodwill that form the bedrock of a supportive relationship.

You Want What?

Given Sentinels' attention to detail and tradition, Protagonists may be frustrated by what seems like a lack of vision. How can their partners become so lost in the nitty-gritty of everyday life and the status quo? Protagonists become bored with conversations that are all about who did what, and when such-and-such is due, and *did you see what she wore to the wedding?* Especially restless, growth-oriented Protagonists may start to see their romantic partners as unimaginative or somehow stunted.

Although the mismatch might not be evident in the earliest days of the partnership, Sentinels' and Protagonists' differing priorities can cause tension as the relationship matures. Just as Protagonists seek even deeper and more meaningful interactions, Sentinels are getting comfortable enough to relax into a stable routine – and expect their partners to settle down accordingly.

Sentinels often have a timeline for when they expect to move in together, get married, buy a home together, have children, and so on. When Protagonists talk about transforming the relationship or soul-searching – their own spin on routine – Sentinels may mistake that desire for disloyalty to the relationship and a violation of how things "should" progress. This dynamic causes hurt on both sides, robbing this couple of the sense that they are growing together over time.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Sentinel Relationships

Back It Up

Although they might resent or dismiss Sentinels' practical mindset at first, Protagonists can come to appreciate it. Sentinel partners offer a

pragmatic counterpoint that can support Protagonists' growth toward the loftiest heights – and even better, it can enable them to grow *together*. Even with Sentinels' support, however, Protagonists might not deliver on their ideas. This creates two problems: On one hand, it bothers ever-conscientious Sentinels, and on the other, it tarnishes Protagonists' self-respect.

To bridge this divide, Protagonists may want to let their partners take the lead, at least in small ways: a weekly meal plan, for instance, or a checklist for the morning routine. With Sentinels creating stability and order, Protagonists may feel clearer-headed, more relaxed, and more capable of the follow-through that their ideas require – which, it just so happens, is also the follow-through that their Sentinel partners expect. When Protagonists deliver on their dreams, their self-image improves alongside their gratitude for their partners. When they express this appreciation, they bolster Sentinels' spirits, which strengthens the relationship. Some suggestions for Protagonists who wish to merge the two approaches:

- When expressing a far-fetched, transitory idea, clarify that it's just a thought experiment. Although Sentinels may not enjoy that kind of conversation, they appreciate knowing whether an idea is going to become a plan.
- If the idea is serious, ask for feedback: "I want to start a business, and I think I could register my trade name with the county within a week. Do you think that's reasonable?"
- Establish a timeline, and explain exactly what kind of accountability or support would be helpful. "Would you check in with me then to see if I've done it? If I fall behind, would you help me create a new schedule?"
- When things go wrong, be honest and ask for help: "I know I'm way behind, and I'm pretty sure I've lost at least half of the paperwork. What do you recommend?" Sentinels shine in such situations.
- Express appreciation and affection for the support and assistance.

Protagonists love to open hearts and minds, and Sentinels can help them be compatible with the world around them. Thanks to a combination of vision and consistency, these couples can support each other through all kinds of endeavors, both large and small.

Gentle Reassurance

When Sentinels resist Protagonists' thirst for transformation and improvement, it's not just because they enjoy the status quo – it's also because they're afraid that their partners will leave them behind. Sentinels may worry that a conversation about moving to a new city or taking up a new hobby will catalyze a chain of events that ends with their Protagonist partner falling out of love, meeting someone new, or otherwise abandoning the plans they've made together. On a smaller scale, Sentinels may feel "forgotten about" when their partner does new things without them. Sentinels crave security, which is one reason that they create mental timelines of how a relationship "should" progress. If they hit each milestone, they reason, that means their life and their relationship are successful. When these types feel vulnerable – for example, when a Protagonist partner suggests a change to the relationship – they cling to their own plans and expectations more tightly.

Once Protagonists appreciate that their partners aren't just being stubborn, they can use their emotional attunement to reassure and include their Sentinel partners whenever they suggest changes. This includes speculative, idle conversations about moving, taking on a new position, or even going new places, as Sentinels might assume that Protagonists intend to follow through on their ideas. Although such conversations are exciting to Protagonists, they can trigger fear, anxiety, and uncertainty among insecure Sentinels.

When Protagonists bring change to Sentinels' doorsteps, they can reassure their partners and coax them out of their shells a little at a time by using a gentle, understanding manner, not to mention a reasonably detailed explanation of the change's practical consequences. Just as importantly, Protagonists can involve their partners in decision-making. By asking for feedback and suggestions on how to implement an idea, Protagonists can draw on their Sentinel partners' incredible strengths – including their pragmatic mindset and their attention to detail. At the same time, this approach allows Protagonists to reassure the person they love that they won't be left behind.

Consider the following:

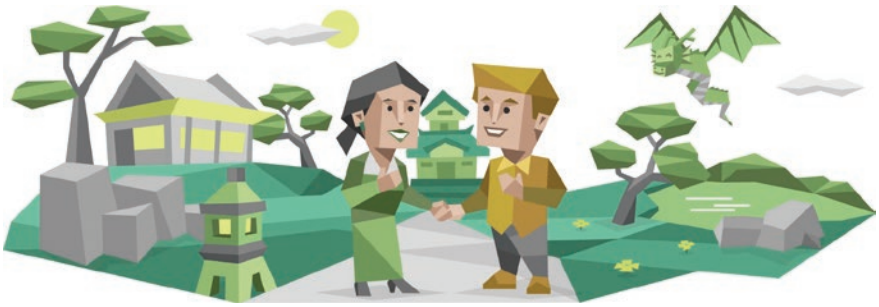
- Before suggesting a change or initiating a soul-searching conversation, consider whether it might be interpreted as a criticism or an invalidation

of your Sentinel partner's desires, plans, and preferences. If so, reframe the conversation in a way that demonstrates commitment and supports the relationship. For example, moving can be viewed as an opportunity to establish a home together.

- If possible, suggest changes only when the environment and mood are conducive to conversation. Traffic jams, crowded places, and the harried few minutes before rushing off to work don't provide the best circumstances.
- Lead off by explaining the tangible benefits of the change: "I've been thinking about going back to school because I think it could open up some new areas for professional growth and help me advance in my career."
- Offer a plan that describes the time and resources that the change would demand – in other words, a budget and a timeline. This clarity prevents your partner from overestimating the impact of the change.
- Ask your Sentinel partner: "How do you feel about this?"
- Ask for feedback on the idea and really listen. The goal is to foster open communication and trust, not to be right (or prove the other person wrong).
- Ask for help implementing or (if appropriate) further researching the change. Emphasize a desire to move forward and develop together as a couple rather than grow apart.
- Remember that Sentinels might experience anxiety when faced with change, so remain attuned to their emotional state. If the conversation becomes too stressful, suggest adjourning it until another time.
- End the conversation by expressing gratitude and affection.

When Protagonists reassure their Sentinel partners, they initiate a virtuous cycle. As Sentinel partners come to understand that the relationship offers deep security and support, they become less rigid about their approach to life in other areas, thereby preventing future tension and unease.

Protagonist–Explorer Relationships



When Protagonists and Explorers find themselves on a date, they discover subtle and not-so-subtle differences between themselves. Explorers are curious about everything, but they become impatient when Protagonists talk about abstractions, values, and philosophies for hours (or days). Provided they appreciate this difference, this couple can thrive on discovery, excitement, and pleasure, enjoying the very best of what life has to offer.

Balanced Protagonist–Explorer Relationships

Red Hot

In the early days of this relationship, sparks fly. Fascinated by Explorers' free spirits and their passionate authenticity, Protagonists detect – or perhaps project – an aura of romance around these adventuresome partners. Explorers come on strong, and Protagonists bask in their energy and attention, immersing themselves fully into the relationship. These two may feel drawn to see each other every day, thrumming with excitement and anticipation as the hour for their date draws near.

Over time, this initial attraction can deepen into true passion. Protagonists' warm, consistent support can help heal any wounds in Explorers' self-esteem or self-image – a dynamic that both partners find gratifying. Meanwhile, Protagonists may be truly touched by the way Explorers feel moved to share the world with them, as Explorers constantly look out for new restaurants, vacations, places, and experiences that the couple can enjoy together. When the initial sparks fade, this combination of consistent support and shared novelty can reinvigorate this relationship through every stage of life.

A Whole New World

With Explorer partners, Protagonists may start to feel their options in life opening. Explorers' spontaneity – for example, sunset dips in the ocean or spur-of-the-moment camping trips – can revive Protagonists' *joie de vivre*, helping them to release the worries of the world and enjoy the moment. Of course, Protagonists aren't in danger of losing their conscience, but a bit of fun can be a welcome respite from the sense of responsibility that usually drives them.

This could all sound awfully superficial, but these partners can teach each other to truly enjoy life – and not because Explorers take Protagonists to hip new restaurants. By teaching Protagonists to live in the moment, their Explorer partners remind them of the fleeting nature of life and the necessity of appreciating the world as it is, even as they work to improve it.

With Explorers' support, Protagonists can step off the implacable treadmill of "I haven't done enough" that makes it so hard for them to rest and recharge. In turn, Protagonists can open Explorers' eyes to the joy of service and contribution. As anyone who volunteers on a regular basis can attest, helping others is one of the greatest happiness boosters on the planet. By expanding each other's horizons in this manner, this couple can enjoy both pleasure and purpose, delight and meaning.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Explorer Relationships

Stubbornness Ensues

As can happen to any couple over time, Protagonist–Explorer couples risk reverting to their core preferences while disregarding the other person's needs. Both types can be stubbornly dedicated to their own perspective and may suffer disconnection if they can't learn to respect each other's approaches to life. Protagonists may find themselves pushing reluctant Explorer partners to examine themselves and discover deep, meaningful change. This cerebral, future-oriented approach may leave experience-oriented Explorer partners feeling disconnected or judged.

Protagonists sometimes focus on the welfare and potential of other people in an all-too-serious way, as if they've agreed to some grim mandate. When Explorers are out with friends on the weekend, the last thing they want to discuss are the injustices committed by some corporation or government. Protagonists' inherent difficulty detaching from this serious mindset, to just have fun when they're "supposed to," can quickly try their Explorer partners' patience. Meanwhile, Protagonists may find themselves wondering just what kind of person can seemingly switch off the part of them that cares when there are more important things in the world than cutting loose.

Me versus We

Protagonists thrive on team effort, and they view themselves and their partners as a dynamic duo. They enjoy collaborating, brainstorming, tackling problems, and generally facing the world with their partner by their side. Explorers, on the other hand – Introverted Explorers in particular – are all about being able to do their own thing. Although they appreciate their partners, they make their decisions independently and prefer not to answer to anyone but themselves.

Some Explorers may go so far as to come home with a car that they hadn't consulted their partner on, but this dynamic can manifest itself in less dramatic ways as well. Protagonists may feel hurt, for example, if their partner faces a major hurdle at work and doesn't ask for their support – or even mention it to them. Protagonists want to help, and when their Explorer partner doesn't want that help, it can feel like a personal affront. It doesn't help if Protagonists offer unsolicited assistance, either, as Explorers may feel smothered, second-guessed, or castigated.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Explorer Relationships

Good Complaining

When Protagonists judge their Explorer partners as shallow or self-interested, they invoke one of the "four horsemen of the apocalypse" identified by relationships researcher John Gottman. Specifically, they criticize, which is among the most toxic communication styles

in a romantic relationship. Paradoxically, if Explorers resist or ignore such judgment, Protagonists might feel more inclined to criticize their partners with greater frequency or force – and more damaging effects. They pave the way for Explorers to react defensively and volley their own recriminations, which can hit sensitive Protagonists hard.

Fortunately, this doesn't mean that the relationship is doomed. According to Gottman, the antidote to criticism is to complain without blame. For example, "You never want to talk about anything deep or meaningful," might become, "I love to share my ideas with you because you mean so much to me. Up for talking through a big idea?" This way, the partners can still express their feelings and their frustrations without wounding each other. The other benefit of this type of communication is that it opens the door for hands-on fixes, which Explorers happily identify and implement.

Steps toward this goal:

- Consider whether the complaint is necessary. Some things simply don't need to be said. When in doubt, wait for one minute before speaking. (Note that this is different from repression. If the frustration grows rather than diminishes with time, it probably needs to be expressed.)
- When in doubt, use a casual, good-humored tone: "Hold up, we didn't agree on that!" Explorers are more likely to be amused by being called out than offended, if it's done in a friendly tone.
- Make a positive request – in other words, ask for something specific in positive terms. "Can we stop talking about the party?" might become, "Could we talk about what's on my mind for a few minutes?"
- Bear in mind that Explorers crave *doing*, not talking. When appropriate, going on a hike or taking a scenic drive can offer a better backdrop for meaningful conversation than hanging around at home.

As positive conversations start to outweigh criticisms, Protagonists can reacquaint themselves with the strengths and gifts of their Explorer partners. Whatever their challenges, the immediacy and tangibility of

Protagonist–Explorer relationships create deeply moving moments for these couples that can overcome challenges of all scales.

Together and Apart

Protagonists want to help, but if taken too far, this can turn into a desire to be involved in every aspect of their partner's life. They may want to go out together whenever possible, even tagging along for errands. And they often look for opportunities to offer advice and support – whether it's wanted or not. When involvement veers into over-involvement, Explorers may react by exerting their independence, shutting their Protagonist partners out of important decisions and aspects of their lives.

It's impossible to control or change anyone. Although Protagonists absolutely have the right to object if their partner doesn't discuss major decisions, changes, or purchases, they can't force Explorers to give up their individualistic streaks. Instead, Protagonists can honestly assess their own behavior, looking for ways that they may have been over-involved or overbearing. They can then choose their battles, distinguishing between what truly matters and what they can let go.

When they want to create more engagement between themselves and their partners, Protagonists can use the following strategies:

- Engage in your partner's interests in much the same way you'd like your partner to engage in yours. Chances are that this will entail asking questions, expressing curiosity, or (if applicable) asking to watch as they work. Chances are that it *won't* entail unsolicited advice or assistance.
    - You can't force an Explorer to express genuine interest about your passions, but you can model the type of engagement that you'd like to receive.
- Look for opportunities to involve your Explorer partner in hands-on activities rather than passive ones. A pottery class or a climbing gym is probably a better destination than a poetry reading.
- Even when your Explorer partner expresses initial reluctance to participate in an activity, they may still have a good time once they're doing it. Using your Intuitive and Feeling traits, you can

learn to distinguish between mild reluctance and true aversion. In the former case, continue to encourage your partner to participate. In the latter, recognize that it's time to back off.

If we could change our partners into whomever we wanted them to be, love would lose its meaning. At times, Explorers' individualism may clash with Protagonists' desire to act as a team. By noticing their own behavior and knowing when to back off (and when to forge onward), Protagonists can avoid being overbearing or pushy as they invite their Explorer partners to spend more time – and emotional energy – together.

Conclusion

Loving Well

A consistent theme throughout Protagonists' lives is thoughtful intention to foster connection and progress – in themselves, in the world, and especially in their relationships with others. When it comes to romantic love, these types are wise to maintain their passion and their loyalty, but they should also look past their exacting views to embrace the varied, grand possibilities that await. With understanding and tolerance, love can be built and sustained beautifully between Protagonists and any other type. There is no perfect match between types, only wonderfully satisfying matches between people who feel drawn to each other and are willing to forgive mistakes, learn, and grow together.

The information in this chapter can help Protagonists on their journey of understanding, both of themselves and in their relationships. It's not always easy to get an accurate sense of just how differently other people think and feel, even for a type as emotionally astute as Protagonists. Learning about other types' needs helps Protagonists increase the objectivity of their own insights, enabling even deeper connections with those who occupy a special place in their hearts.

Moving Forward Together

To Protagonists, the best romantic relationships aren't passive. Shared laughs and pleasure are only part of a fulfilling relationship, particularly in the long term. Protagonists want conscious, progressive action with their partners.

When lovers happily occupy large portions of each other's lives, the less glamorous or pleasant aspects of their lives also become intertwined. Everyone has flaws and baggage, and expecting each other to handle such things alone or out of sight doesn't create the kind of interconnected relationships that Protagonists crave. Rebalancing is all about facing each other's issues with patience, love, and forgiveness, as well as taking deliberate steps together in the real world to work things out.

Protagonists love to think, dream, and understand things in their heads, but thought is only the first stage of progress – in life and in love. Finding practical ways to cooperate and compromise with romantic partners is key to moving forward together. This applies equally to achieving hopes and dreams and to maintaining personal freedom and individuality.

The rebalancing sections above give just some ideas on how Protagonists and their partners can respect each other while getting what they need to be happy. Although it's unrealistic to believe that any relationship will be all sunshine, it's fully possible to master difficult times together and walk out the other side smiling, hand in hand. Protagonists can create this happy path for themselves with those they love.

Parenthood

Ethical and Inspirational

Protagonist parents strive to impress on their children the importance of an ethical approach to the world's problems, yet there's a hopefulness to their view of life that ensures these lessons are often more uplifting than chiding. With these parents, fairy tales are used for their intended purpose – to offer lessons to their children on how to fight for what is right and stand up to injustice. As an aspirational type, they expect their children not to be perfect, but to always be on a journey to becoming something better, for themselves and all people.

At their best, Protagonist parents are warm, loving, firm, and unwavering, a combination of traits that provides their kids with the freedom and support to pursue their goals. These traits also steer them as far away as possible from the more dangerous pitfalls of youth. Protagonist parents play active roles in their children's lives, guiding them with love and support but also with a firm refusal to enable any behavior that they see as morally misguided or self-destructive.

Devoted and Open-Minded

Though Protagonists can stretch themselves thin by taking on all the world's problems at once, their attention is seldom so divided that they can't lavish a generous portion on those closest to them. Nothing inspires these types like a great cause, and shepherding their offspring can be their most important endeavor. Protagonist parents who remember that their children need space, as well as intimacy, have little trouble maintaining strong bonds with their progeny for years.

Although parents with this personality type feel that no effort should be spared to ensure their children's health and well-being, they don't hesitate to voice their concerns in a respectful, age-appropriate way. They'll push their children to be moral, compassionate, and considerate of others while also holding them accountable for their choices and behavior. Protagonists have high expectations for their kids that they don't hesitate to make known – however, they welcome discussion with their children over moral disagreements. When they're confident in their values and beliefs, Protagonist parents can support their children throughout their lives as they develop their own identities and beliefs.

Unrealistic Expectations

Despite their best intentions, all parents struggle with various aspects of parenting. It's inevitable that parents become overwhelmed and stressed at some point. Losing their temper is familiar enough, but exceptionally frustrated Protagonist parents can face a crisis. If their children commit an unexpected lapse in moral judgment (as is bound to happen sometime), these parents may let their imaginations run wild, reading sweeping moral failures in simple mistakes.

Protagonists' high moral standards also mean that things other personality types might shrug off can offend them deeply. Because they identify so strongly with the beliefs they hold, few things hurt Protagonists more than seeing their children challenge or even reject them. Protagonist parents may blame themselves for instilling the wrong values in their children, and they may try to fix that through emotionally manipulative behaviors.

Pushy Parents

As open-minded as these types can be, if their passion for a specific belief gets out of hand, they can become downright demanding. When they commit to a specific ideology and expect their kids to follow, the scales can tip from inspiring to dogmatic. Different methods work best, based on children's needs: Parents who stubbornly focus on one educational ideology risk doing more harm than good.

Forcing an uninterested preschooler to take Mandarin classes or insisting that their introverted teenager join a club or sports team for more social interaction inevitably breeds spite and bitterness. The

intentions behind these efforts may be noble, but when Protagonist parents fail to share their passions, they may end up with children who automatically reject their ideas and beliefs.

Practicing Forgiveness

Parents with this personality type may have a hard time aligning their expectations with reality, especially when it comes to moral and ethical scenarios. When they feel as though they've violated their moral code, perhaps by yelling at their toddlers or giving their teenagers unreasonable punishments, Protagonist parents can be exceptionally tough on themselves. They often find it difficult to forgive themselves for failing to uphold their high standards.

There's nothing wrong with high personal expectations, but an inability to forgive themselves – or others – for failures can ultimately result in bitter, unhappy parents. Parenting is hard, and all parents, no matter how noble and moral, make mistakes – a *lot* of mistakes. The key to happy, balanced parenting is finding ways to forgive mistakes and look, instead, for signs of growth and improvement. Focusing on what they've done right – like figuring out effective ways to calm their toddlers' tantrums – instead of their mistakes can lead to more contentment and fulfillment in their relationships with both themselves and their children.

Inspiring Independence

As much as they may believe that they're encouraging their children by helping them solve all their problems, Protagonist parents who don't allow their kids to struggle and learn from their mistakes are doing them a disservice. Fortunately, they can easily transform that same passion they have for encouraging their children into a passion for promoting their growth and development. Many Protagonists consider themselves aficionados in personal development, as they seek and engage in growth opportunities themselves. Their drive to constantly improve and evolve is inspirational and can help them serve as mentors to their children.

The key to inspiring healthy independence is to provide the proper balance of challenge and support to children throughout their lives. Kids

shouldn't wallow in confusion, but parents shouldn't be too quick to jump in and solve their problems, either. Allowing children to experience failure is just as important as supporting them during their greatest trials. Kids who "forget" to study for their history test must accept the consequences of their behavior (i.e., not paying attention, being disorganized). Instead of swooping in to "save" them, Protagonist parents should help them cope with these consequences and learn from them.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of children's growth presents both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachments and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages aren't set in stone, and the ages listed for each stage are approximate. Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time, often even skipping stages, achieving them in an unexpected order, or trying one milestone out and falling back to an old one – this is especially common with learning to walk. This is often normal, but it's worth developing a relationship with a pediatric physician to check in with any questions and concerns.

The following paragraphs discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Protagonist personality type affect their parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (from Birth to Approximately 1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created as parents meet children's needs, develop trusting relationships, and promote autonomy.

The main priority for infants on the journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, infants

either learn to trust that their Protagonist parents provide for them or suffer from a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships. If parents are inconsistent or neglectful in providing for their children, their infants have difficulty creating a positive, trusting attachment with them.

On the other hand, attentive and affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact – such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their bodies – encourage trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have minimal difficulty building comfortable attachments.

Balanced Infant Bonding

Building Loving Bonds

Few things in life are as exciting as bringing home a new baby, and Protagonists, with their desire to connect with others, find this stage particularly satisfying. Protagonists who tap into their empathy and sensitivity when their children are born have no trouble giving their infants the attention and affection needed to build loving bonds. Infants need affection that goes beyond just daily care. They crave the physical connection that their parents provide through cuddling, rocking, speaking softly, and making eye contact. Parents' loving smiles do more than just entertain their infants – they create a primal connection that inspires the trust they need to develop positive relationships.

As parents, Protagonists thrive on feeling needed and enjoy being their children's primary caretakers. This is vital, as it can motivate them during the extraordinarily draining infant stage. Some parents may struggle with maintaining energy during this phase, thus creating mood swings or other inconsistent behaviors, but Protagonists' seemingly ceaseless energy and their reliability allow them to not only survive this stage but even relish it.

Motivated Caretakers

Loving bonds, as discussed previously, are important. Even more so, motivated Protagonists truly excel at being eager to alter their lives to meet their infants' needs. The moment their children are born, the

first time they smile, and when they say "momma" or "dada" – these are all meaningful, motivating experiences. Protagonist parents live for these simple moments, from cuddling with their sleepy, satiated babies in their rocking chairs to making silly faces at them while changing their diapers. Few parents are as attuned to, and appreciative of, the meaningful moments that build loving bonds with their children as Protagonists are.

One of the greatest Protagonist strengths is their selfless concern for others. Caring for infants, who are utterly reliant on others to meet their needs, may drain parents of other personality types. Protagonist parents, however, truly thrive on what most would consider an exhausting mission, where they're required to put their personal needs on hold to care for a completely dependent child. Protagonists view building empathic, emotional bonds with their children as their number one priority throughout the lifespan. The infancy stage, for these parents, is one of the most rewarding times to interact and bond with their children.

Unbalanced Infant Bonding

Taking on Too Much

Many new parents experience a great deal of pressure to maintain their pre-infant lifestyles after their children are born. When Protagonist parents become too focused on living up to unrealistic expectations placed by either themselves or others, they may find themselves taking on more than they can handle. People with this personality type often manage a full plate of obligations even before they have children, and both new parents and veterans alike may attempt to play the role of "super parents" by jumping back into work right away or obsessing about keeping up with a busy social calendar. When Protagonists insist on returning to their pre-parenthood (or pre–new child) grind before they're ready, they end up overtaxing themselves physically, mentally, spiritually, and emotionally.

To further complicate matters, Protagonists, with their innate leadership abilities, often feel that it's their role to help others. Asking for help, even when they truly need it, can be extraordinarily difficult for those

who identify as the "helper." The infant and toddler years are some of the most challenging that parents face, and an unwillingness to seek or accept help from others dramatically increases the possibility that Protagonist parents will experience frustration, exhaustion, and even an uncharacteristic lack of motivation.

Struggling with Expectations

In addition to struggling with taking on too much, Protagonists may have unrealistic expectations of what they can teach their children at this stage. They may believe that their infants should be able to achieve certain milestones more quickly than is necessary or fret that their children aren't hitting milestones "on time." Anxious Protagonist parents may be more concerned about teaching their children to sit up, roll over, feed themselves, or walk before they're truly ready, rather than appreciating their children's current abilities and engaging with them at their level.

It's certainly exciting to see their babies roll over for the first time or sit up on their own, but pushing children to achieve these milestones causes frustration for both parties involved. Just because their brilliant infants aren't saying their first words at the same time as their friends' children doesn't mean that they aren't on track developmentally. Development isn't a measure of parental ability, and both Protagonist parents and their infants end up much happier and more relaxed if they're allowed to mature at their own pace.

Rebalancing Infant Bonding

Seeking Support

Learning to balance their needs with their children's needs is one of the most important things that Protagonists can do. To do this, they need to take time to understand and accept their own limits. It's not unreasonable for new parents to request the maximum time off after the birth of a child or to let people know they'll just be stopping by this year's fundraiser rather than organizing it. Being healthy parents is more important than being "super parents," and it is much more realistic as well.

Although Protagonists tend to feel guilty (and even self-indulgent) when they put their needs ahead of the needs of others, they will find that doing so makes them happier, healthier parents. There are many ways to take quality time, but not everyone has the time (or resources) to take a weekend retreat, get weekly massages, or even take a daily 15-minute nap. The following suggestions can be effective ways for busy, burned-out Protagonist parents to recharge in just a few minutes:

- Enjoy a 30-minute bath while a partner or friend puts the kids to bed.
- Take a relative up on their offer to babysit.
- Meet with friends for coffee at home or a coffee shop once a week.
- Engage in a deep breathing exercise or yoga stretches for five minutes.
- Join a club or group such as a book club, sports team, parent support group, or any other "adults-only" activity that allows for time to interact with others without being distracted by children (even if it's only for a brief amount of time).
- Regularly share thoughts or feelings with a friend or partner.

Prioritizing Attachment

Protagonists prepare themselves to be extraordinary teachers, but when it comes to promoting their infants' development, they may be more pushy than helpful. Offering their children unconditional love and support, especially at such a young age, is much more important than cultivating genius. When they're intent on seeing their infants "make progress" in their growth and development, even the most well-meaning Protagonist parents may sacrifice some of the beauty of a loving parent-child bond.

The most important development that needs to take place during this stage is a loving attachment between parent and child. Such a bond can create the foundation for the rest of the child's development. Learning to crawl is important, but having parents who love and support them unconditionally, regardless of their abilities, is much more important. The following activities can help Protagonist parents bond with and appreciate their infants *right now*:

- Read out loud. Children's stories are ideal but not necessary, as small babies gain a lot just by hearing their parents speak.
- Practice baby wearing. Parents can do many chores and activities (like sweeping or shopping) while babies are in wearable carriers. This contact promotes bonding and helps even the fussiest babies fall asleep – bonus!
- Engage in skin-to-skin contact as often as possible, especially with young infants.
- Write down infants' milestones (first smile, first tooth, and so on) to keep track of their progress.

Testing Boundaries (from Approximately 1½ to 3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and communicating verbally are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Protagonist parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Children who can test boundaries yet still receive parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. Toddlers who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for testing boundaries ultimately experience shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last throughout their lives, perhaps jeopardizing their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Bonding

Compassionate and Engaged

Extremely supportive, Protagonists make an ideal "home base" for their children during this stage. Their focus on meaningful engagement with their children, combined with a sincere determination to meet their needs, ensures that their toddlers never feel abandoned, ignored, or

unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers, and Protagonists don't disappoint.

Protagonists' compassion is especially useful during the trying toddler years. This stage can certainly be challenging, but confident parents with this personality type enjoy promoting their children's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take pleasure in helping their children learn how to pick out their own clothes and dress themselves while also promoting their toddlers' natural creativity and self-expression. Helping their kids learn to become creative, self-reliant, and competent are among Protagonist parents' greatest joys.

Nurturing Creative Connections

As far as parent-child activities are concerned, these parents prioritize open-minded, active engagement as a means of emotional bonding. People with this personality type enjoy things that excite their visionary spirit, and they rarely have difficulty coming up with thoughtful, unique ideas. Providing opportunities for their children to learn and experience new and different things is especially important to Protagonist parents, who thrive on pursuing such opportunities for themselves as well.

The toddler stage is devoted to exploration of all kinds, from trying different foods to discovering new places. These parents are more than happy to provide opportunities for their children to experience the world around them. Many Protagonists love nature and believe in respect for all living things. They encourage their toddlers to experience and enjoy nature as well, whether it means taking day trips or weekend outings to parks and reserves or stopping to take a closer look at flowers, birds, and insects. These activities offer parents an excellent opportunity to teach their children the importance of empathy, kindness, and the world around them.

Unbalanced Toddler Bonding

Difficulty with Defiance

If they take their toddlers' willful or defiant behavior personally, Protagonist parents will find this stage especially challenging. It can be

both frustrating and discouraging when their lovingly raised children begin using their newly acquired favorite word, "No!" in response to their questions. From throwing a fit every evening at bedtime to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem intent on challenging their parents at every turn. As much as they want to foster their children's independence, Protagonists who believe "the parent always knows what's best" undoubtedly struggle when their children ignore their wisdom.

The toddler stage is when identity development begins, so children don't always behave in ways that fit their parents' molds. Behaviors such as hitting their siblings or yelling at their parents – which are, although not desirable, normal for this stage – can be especially demoralizing for Protagonists who feel that their children's moral development should be further along at this point. When these parents are more focused on idealized versions of their children, they may miss opportunities to support what's unique about their toddlers.

Overly Involved

Protagonist parents may believe they're supportive, engaging parents, but a misguided tendency to provide too many structured activities can stunt their toddlers' development. Structured or educational games may seem to promote learning when, in reality, children need to learn how to generate their own ideas and solve real-world problems.

Similarly, if Protagonists step in every time their child argues with another, it impedes social development by preventing the child from learning on their own to resolve conflict. Constant interventions at the toddler stage can result in children who expect that every issue will be solved for them, which can result in a failure to take responsibility for their own behavior. Despite their best intentions, overly involved Protagonists run the risk of limiting their toddlers' ability to deal with the challenges they face as they grow older.

Rebalancing Toddler Bonding

Modeling Respectful Behavior

As much as Protagonists love to promote their children's growth, it can

be disheartening to watch their formerly cuddly and relatively docile infants transform into defiant, raging "No" machines. Although they may wonder what happened to their sweet babies, Protagonist parents can take heart: The toddler stage is just that, a *stage*. Wild mood swings and forceful gestures of independence – like screaming and running through the grocery store when they don't get the cereal they want – should balance out once they're school-aged.

It's especially important for Protagonist parents to understand that their children are establishing their autonomy. Children this age aren't intentionally rejecting their parents: Much like college students who party when they're supposed to be studying, toddlers are pushing boundaries as part of finding their own way. Just because children are becoming more independent, however, doesn't mean that parents should allow them to get away with demanding behavior. Protagonist parents still need to redirect their children and model the appropriate ways to behave. Some ways to do this:

- Teach toddlers to raise their hands or place their hands on a parent's arm if they need to speak instead of interrupting – their parents will know they have something to say and still get to finish their sentences.
- Use techniques such as laughing or clapping loudly rather than shouting, "No!" when children are engaging in undesirable behaviors.
- Practice labeling emotions using pictures (smiley face, sad face, angry face) and have toddlers point to the faces that match their emotions. This should eventually help them feel understood rather than feeling as though they must act on their emotions.
- Read stories where problems are solved with good behavior and emotional control, such as *Little Blue Truck*, *Where the Wild Things Are*, and *The Runaway Bunny*.

Focusing on Appropriate Growth

Doing too much for their children can be just as damaging as inconsistent discipline, but with some of their own personal discipline and development, Protagonist parents can prevent or undo any

negative consequences of their constant interventions. The most effective way to do this is to tap into their natural desire to encourage their children and their ability to persuade others.

Protagonist parents can encourage their toddlers' development by regularly looking for opportunities to promote growth, problem-solving skills, and autonomy. Their focus should be on fostering age-appropriate development and encouraging kids to practice certain skills, including gross motor skills (such as walking, jumping, and running) and fine motor skills (such as stacking blocks and putting together simple puzzles). The following actions can allow Protagonists to support their children while also inspiring independence:

- Give toddlers a few clothing options (two or three) to pick out when they get dressed, have them try pouring their own cereal, and encourage them to wash their own hands and face after mealtime.
- Make time for play and allow the children to lead the way with participatory imaginative play.
- Encourage them to resolve conflicts through sharing and using kind words – and resist the temptation to solve the issue for them.

Thirst for Knowledge (from Approximately 3 to 5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Preschoolers absorb information constantly, through restless activity and a seemingly unending stream of questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured and imaginary kind, and through social interaction with family and peers. They also exercise creativity through make-believe games and stories.

If children don't have the opportunity to set the agenda occasionally, or if their constant questions or childish make-believe games are received with annoyance, kids can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and incompetence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative. Parents who wish to navigate this stage successfully must give their children the opportunity to make some of their own

decisions, initiate activities, ask questions, receive answers, and lead others in exploratory play.

Balanced Preschool Relationships

Excellent Teachers

As proponents of lifelong learning, Protagonist parents genuinely want to inspire their children to enjoy learning. People with this personality type happily answer their preschool children's stream of questions and take great pleasure in creatively engaging them in learning opportunities. From trips to the library to impromptu nature "classes" while walking to the park, Protagonists take any chance they can to engage and educate their preschoolers.

Seeking out educational opportunities isn't the only form of teaching that these parents engage in – modeling morals and values for their children from a young age is as important to them as other forms of learning. Protagonist parents teach their preschoolers to respect others and appreciate their differences. They insist on integrity: If their children dig up a neighbor's flowers, these parents would encourage their little ones to apologize to neighbor, then help them understand why digging up those flowers was wrong. Protagonists feel it's their moral obligation to instill these important values through modeling and consistent encouragement.

Emotionally Intelligent

Emotional engagement is a high priority – both in terms of building strong bonds with their children and teaching them how to develop their emotional intelligence. Kids at this stage are learning the importance of self-control, empathy, and interpersonal relationships (especially with peers) and need guidance to properly develop these skills.

Children best learn emotional intelligence through modeling, and this is where Protagonist parents can truly shine. Those who have developed their own self-control and can engage in genuine, thoughtful ways can lovingly communicate these concepts to their children. Imaginary play is an especially useful outlet for practicing these skills. Something as simple as playing a game of "house" with their children can be a perfect

opportunity for these parents to both model healthy relationships and lovingly correct inappropriate behavior. Parents who engage in this type of play with their preschoolers pass along wisdom and enhance their emotional bonds as well.

Unbalanced Preschool Relationships

Exceedingly Ambitious

Protagonists rarely struggle to maintain the energy necessary to keep up with their children. However, they tend to overestimate how much they themselves and their preschoolers can accomplish in a single day. Busyness may energize these parents, but their young children may not benefit from a packed schedule of playdates, art classes, and errands with little time for rest or free play. This incessant action and limited opportunities to exercise their free will plant the seeds of future resentfulness and rebellion.

There's also a danger that Protagonist parents who fall into the "overachiever" trap can become overworked and overwhelmed during this stage. Just keeping up with housework, a career, and the myriad needs of an entire household can exhaust anyone. Life at this stage becomes even more challenging when parents must now also run their children from preschool to playdates to swimming lessons and karate class. Parents in today's digital society can also feel burdened by the need to make every birthday party and family vacation worthy of posting on social media. Attempting to achieve "perfect parent" status can quickly take a toll on Protagonists, who would prefer to focus on more meaningful aspects of life.

Overestimating Abilities

During the preschool years, children are transitioning from completely dependent infants to increasingly independent individuals. As their little ones grow more competent and communicative, these parents risk overestimating their preschoolers' capabilities. Their desire to one day view their kids as equals can result in early unrealistic expectations that frustrate both parents and children.

Protagonists, as morally focused individuals, may assume that their preschoolers can easily grasp any ideas or moral constructs. This is especially true when the information they provide is hypothetical. Saying, "You shouldn't hit people. How would you feel if someone hit you?" seems like a perfectly reasonable question. However, children at this stage are incapable of putting themselves in other people's shoes. They may respond, "I would feel bad," but what they're really thinking is, "I would feel bad if someone hit me, but what I really feel bad about right now is getting in trouble." Empathy and moral reasoning are still undeveloped at this stage, and Protagonist parents who expect their children to be proficient in these skills struggle to communicate effectively (and appropriately) with their preschoolers.

Rebalancing Preschool Relationships

Adjusting Expectations

Rather than letting their ambition drive both themselves and their children to the brink of burnout, Protagonist parents must learn to say, "No," to endless playdates and nature classes, and say, "Yes," to a much-needed break when necessary. Children benefit more from getting rest and having freedom than from attending every class, sport, and extracurricular activity possible. Unstructured playtime provides preschoolers with a creative outlet and encourages self-initiation – both necessities for successfully navigating this stage.

Although Protagonist parents may initially feel some guilt for not meeting societal expectations – or their own overly ambitious ones – they ultimately feel will liberated from unnecessary obligations. Their natural tendency is to live life based on their values, not social dictates, and they must find their way back to those values as they raise their children. It's also important for people with this personality type to find ways to take care of themselves while parenting their preschoolers. Here are some ideas that can help bring balance to this busy stage:

- Limit activities such as playdates, sports, art classes, etc., to just a couple of times per week rather than every other day.
- Resist the temptation to make sure that every event or activity is social media worthy.

- Schedule regular breaks such as parent date nights, drinks with friends, or solo walks in nature – anything that's recharging and refreshing.
- Spend quality time with preschoolers with no agenda or expectations.

Protagonist parents who provide a primarily peaceful, relaxed environment will experience happier, healthier relationships with their children.

Accepting Age-Appropriate Abilities

The preschool stage is one of the most delightful, as children at this age can communicate with and understand their parents far more effectively than they could in earlier years. Parents who can focus on the progress that children have made are more successful in their interactions than those who dwell on their undeveloped skills.

From silly jokes to profound questions, preschoolers often display a type of genius that's truly inspiring. Additionally, their authenticity is unparalleled at this stage, making them capable of sincere, compassionate interactions with others. Despite their undeveloped moral reasoning and empathy, preschoolers are capable of affection and kindness, traits that endear them to even the most frustrated or flabbergasted parents. Protagonists who recognize their preschoolers' strengths find it easier to remain optimistic when they're faced with their shortcomings. The following brief exercise can help Protagonist parents appreciate their children exactly as they are:

- Sit down at a table with your preschooler, a box of crayons, and several blank pieces of paper.
- Have the child tell stories and illustrate them by drawing pictures (help by drawing and writing the stories down).
- Collect the drawings and make them into a book by binding them with staples or string.
- Sit back and admire the genius and creativity that your preschooler is capable of.

Creating Competence (from Approximately 5 to 12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. They're still constantly absorbing new information, and they're also developing proficiency in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are challenged and supported in these areas flourish in both their abilities and self-confidence.

If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers, and they will be less likely to develop or work toward long-term goals. On the other hand, if they aren't sufficiently challenged, they can begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities, and they may come to lack modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced School-Age Relationships

Passionate and Encouraging

Protagonists are disproportionately drawn to working in education, and they are ardent supporters of lifelong learning. However, passing spelling tests and memorizing multiplication tables aren't as important to Protagonists as having children who are creative and compassionate in their success. If they feel their kids aren't receiving a truly holistic education, Protagonist parents can explore alternative options such as tutoring, charter schools, or even homeschooling to fill in the gaps.

Ever the compassionate parents, these types provide both support and encouragement to children who are struggling. They're careful to ensure that their high expectations don't prevent them from being understanding and empathetic. Children are expected to put effort into gaining knowledge and developing their skills, but Protagonist parents won't hesitate to come to the aid of those who are struggling with a certain class or the school bully. At the same time, they encourage their children to work toward finding solutions to problems themselves, which helps children achieve a sense of balanced competence that's necessary at this stage of development.

Excellent Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, and Protagonists

are natural mentors who can model the skills needed for success in academics. These parents eagerly teach their children the value of hard work and stress the importance of traits such as innovation and creativity. Few types understand the necessity of these traits the way Protagonists do.

At a stage in life when kids are constantly being told what to do and conforming to strict schedules, innovation and creativity often become neglected or viewed as unnecessary. Imaginative Protagonist parents understand the importance of these traits in an ever-changing world and encourage their children to incorporate their unique ideas and perspectives into both their academic and personal lives. They may also encourage their children to explore the arts – visual, performing, or literary – whether attending a performance of *The Nutcracker* together or enrolling their would-be ballerinas in dancing lessons. For Protagonist parents, creative expression is much more vital than financial success or the status of a profession or title.

Unbalanced School-Age Relationships

Passionately Out of Touch

Protagonists' passion for a cause can create issues for their children at this stage if it isn't properly balanced with their children's needs and abilities. School-aged children certainly benefit from volunteering and standing up for their beliefs. However, they also need parents who can help them address the issues they face in day-to-day life. From a school crush that isn't reciprocated to the trauma of being picked last for the kickball team, children at this age need parents who can help them deal with personal issues that deeply affect them.

Always focused on saving the world, Protagonist parents may fail to validate their children's feelings on these "smaller issues," perhaps finding that their kids are less likely to seek their help or support in the future. Sure, the world isn't going to end if their sons or daughters don't make the basketball team, but it can feel catastrophic. To children at this age, everything that happens to them is a big deal. Protagonist parents who don't help their children deal with their issues in balanced and effective ways often struggle to maintain close relationships.

Pretentiously Idealistic

Although they may not concern themselves with typical achievements and awards, Protagonists can be rather demanding parents when it comes to measuring up to their ideals. When their expectations are more idealistic than realistic, they may become paranoid that their children won't live up to the values and principles they've outlined. Having their children turn out to be cynical, irresponsible, or apathetic is among Protagonist parents' greatest fears.

One of the greatest demands these parents make stems from a fear of something less sinister, however – being ordinary. They set ambitious life targets for themselves and stand up against evil in the name of high moral goals, through acts big and small. They may never be able to declare victory, but they know in their hearts that they fight the good fight. They expect the same of their children – with freedom, strength of will, and dreams, their children could change the world!

But their kids may want a simple, stable life. Rather than declaring war on the injustice in the world, they may just want happy lives being moderately popular and maintaining decent grades. Overly idealistic Protagonists can struggle to understand that this is as valid and desirable as any other path because it's what their children feel is right for *them*.

Rebalancing School-Age Relationships

Meeting Them Where They Are

Well-meaning Protagonists place high expectations on their children, hoping that it encourages them to make a difference in the world. Unfortunately, when the focus is constantly on what is expected – especially when the expectations are extraordinary – these parents are apt to miss out on what their children really need. What kids need most from their parents is unconditional love and acceptance, combined with mutual goals and reasonable boundaries, and Protagonist parents are more than capable of providing them.

Those who are prone to fixating on the "big picture" can benefit from focusing on what their children are dealing with now – this the

big picture, for them. Rather than trying to hammer a square peg (Protagonist parents' idea of what is important) into a round hole (what their children think is important), these parents should make a point to engage with their children in the "here and now." Some ideas that can help:

- Start a gratitude practice where both parents and children state three things they're grateful for that day and one thing that's bothering them.
- Incorporate a mindfulness practice into your routine, perhaps with the gratitude practice, where parents and children spend five minutes focusing on deep, focused breathing.
- Set aside time weekly where parents and children can engage in activities together, such as hitting up an arcade, taking a hike, or checking out a museum.

Children face significant challenges as they navigate this stage, and support from their parents is necessary for them to not only achieve competence but also learn how to interact with others in a compassionate and understanding way.

Embracing Individual Perspectives

As much as Protagonist parents may want their children to focus on vanquishing all the evils of the world, it's more important that they focus on promoting their overall well-being. They're very devoted to their values, especially reliability, integrity, and social justice, as well as their children. Using their devotion, Protagonists can create definitions of personal success that embrace the individual perspectives their children possess.

Protagonists should encourage their children to develop their own values and pursue their own definitions of a successful life, which can undoubtedly go through multiple iterations as they grow, learn, and evolve. This can be done by looking at the institutions that have played an important part in their lives, such as their faith, their family, or clubs in which they're involved. Although Protagonists' values may be noble, their children's confidence and sense of identity depend on their abilities to determine their own values without judgment, even if

their idea of a meaningful life doesn't match that of their parents. The following exercise can help Protagonist parents practice accepting and encouraging their children's dreams and ideas while withholding their tendency to judge them:

- Write down one important value. Include at least two reasons why it's important.
- Imagine a friend or loved one criticizing that value, and write down the feelings that would trigger.
- Use this information to consider how judgmental behavior toward the values of others, especially children, can make them feel.

Find Thyself (from Approximately 12 to 18 Years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood, when children focus on developing their own distinct identities. This transitional period centers around their individual sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents at this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. They make educational and future career goals and develop relationships based on how they align with their values and beliefs, making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Relationships

Promoting Positive Values

During this stage of identity development, older children need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Protagonist parents encourage their adolescents' growth by promoting positive values, such as respect, compassion, and integrity, while also providing them with freedom to explore other values that inspire them. Mature Protagonists understand the importance of allowing their teens to go through the difficult yet necessary process of personal development with the proper balance of support and stepping back.

Regardless of the struggles Protagonists may face during this tumultuous time, they remain steadfast in their devotion to their

children. Their dedication, both to their kids and to the promotion of positive values, provides a solid foundation that allows identity-seeking children to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of support and love.

Unconditional Love and Commitment

People often make personal identity discoveries through trial and error, which often translates into mistakes. Protagonist parents' unconditional love and support are indispensable as they help their teens cope with the many challenges they face. An adolescent who skips class needs to know that there are consequences to their behavior but also that their parents still love them regardless of their mistakes. Children at this stage are more likely to communicate with their parents if they're confident that they won't be judged and aren't at risk of having their parents' love and acceptance revoked.

This is especially true when they're dealing with something truly serious: a pregnancy, suspension or expulsion, or even painful milestones like a rough breakup. Protagonist parents who stay loving toward their children during these dilemmas can establish themselves as true sources of empathy and wisdom when their children need it most. As overwhelming and terrifying as some of these situations are, Protagonists who can tap into their compassion and forward-thinking natures can confront these situations from places of wisdom rather than of panic. Beyond treating their adolescents with respect, Protagonists can strive to be the wise, understanding adults in the room.

Unbalanced Adolescent Relationships

Imposing Ideals

Like the issues they faced during their children's school-aged years, Protagonists who have unrealistic expectations of their adolescents' identity development struggle with their ever-expanding independence. People with this personality type are very accepting of the pursuit of personal development, but they may have their own ideas about what this process should look like and what values their children should espouse. Protagonists with passionate political or religious views may

find their children's desire to explore seemingly "oppositional" beliefs insulting, even worth undoing based on principle alone.

Protagonist parents who believe that personal development can be accomplished only within specific, approved parameters – regardless of where those boundaries fall on any scale – may inadvertently prevent their adolescents from going through the self-discovery process. Adolescents are unlikely to respond well to this type of parental control and may act out in rebellious ways or shut down and stop communicating with their parents altogether.

Overly Sensitive

Because of their sensitivity and focus on morality, Protagonists are hurt deeply by things other personality types might shrug off. Few things are more hurtful to them than seeing their deeply held morals and beliefs flaunted, especially by their children. When they're feeling insecure about their parenting, they may blame themselves for being unable to instill the right values in their children, and they may try to fix the problem by resorting to increasingly intense moral and emotional appeals.

Teenagers often rebel against their parents' authority by actively exploring new and often contrary ideas. But parents shouldn't immediately assume that their teens are sincerely opposed to their beliefs or that all their teachings have been ignored. Whether such assumptions are grounded in truth or not, they can feel deeply hurt. If they then focus on mitigating damage and strengthening their relationships in cloying or manipulative ways, Protagonists may create even stronger pushback. If they let their sensitivity get the best of them, they can forget that they, too, once craved freedom and independence when they were teens, especially when it came to the pursuit of ideas and ideals. Their children are likely to recognize and appreciate this, which should help make adolescence less chaotic.

Rebalancing Adolescent Relationships

Celebrating Individual Ideals

Discovering ideals that are personally meaningful is one of the most

important aspects of identity development for Protagonists. Rather than being offended or insulted if their children's ideals don't match their own, mature parents with this personality type can celebrate the fact that their adolescents have gone through this same process of self-discovery. If their children understand right and wrong and have well-developed moral compasses, Protagonists can take a step back and appreciate a parenting job well done.

The best way for parents to encourage their teens to develop their own personal ideals is to encourage them to privately focus on embracing values that are meaningful to their individual journeys. Although they can be encouraged to draw from family values during this process, it's important for Protagonist parents to avoid pressuring or trying to "guilt" their adolescents into agreeing with their own values and beliefs. The following exercise can help Protagonist parents guide their teenagers through this process. Protagonists can have their teenagers answer the following questions to get them started:

- Think about the times in your life when you have felt the happiest and most successful. What did they have in common?
- Keeping those moments in mind, use a list or a mind map and write down the words that remind you of those times. If getting a high school diploma was something that made you feel successful, writing the values, "love of learning" or "perseverance" would be appropriate.
- Choose five to 10 values from the list or mind map.
- Figure out a way to implement those values. Make sure to start with one at a time. If "love of learning" is one of your values, consider signing up for an online course, or try learning a new language.

Improving Understanding of Themselves and Others

One of the best ways to counter a tendency to be overly sensitive is for teens to improve their understanding of themselves and others. If Protagonist parents are unaware of their own triggers that make them feel insecure or offended, it's easy for them to get carried away with any perceived slights. Likewise, if they fail to understand that their children have their own unique values and personality traits, they may assume

that they're defiant or difficult. Despite the amount of influence that these parents have over their teens, it's important to both respect and support their differences. They may not choose to be vegans like their parents, but that doesn't mean that they don't value life or love the environment any less.

Parenthood provides the opportunity for Protagonists to learn from their children and grow as human beings. Sometimes parenting can bring out the worst – like yelling at a teenager who has failed to clean up their room *again* – but it also brings out the best and most authentic parts of their personalities. Protagonists are especially selfless parents, and their self-sacrifice and compassion won't go unnoticed, even though adolescents might take it for granted for some time. Reflecting on areas of parenthood that are especially hard, like dealing with rebellious teenagers, can allow people with this personality type to see what aspects of themselves they need to improve or balance.

The following brief exercise can help Protagonist parents take negative interactions with their teens and turn them into learning experiences:

- Think of a recent argument or misunderstanding with your adolescent.
- Imagine how the teen felt, then write down how they may have felt during this disagreement (frustrated, angry, misunderstood, hurt).
- Write down any reactions (or expectations) that may have been unreasonable.
- Consider how these unreasonable reactions or expectations may have exacerbated frustrations during this disagreement.
- Finally, take a moment to consider what type of response would respectfully get the point across while also maintaining an understanding of the teen's opinions.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Protagonists have their own unique strengths, such as inspiration, altruism, leadership, and integrity, that they can leverage, as well as weaknesses they can try

to understand and overcome to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. Parents have tremendous potential for personal development, and Protagonists can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

Every child is different, and parents are the best judge of what their children need. The advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Protagonists share. Use this information however it works best – if any of the advice or guidance adds additional stress, frustration, or burden, set it aside. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to come up with a plan that works best for everyone involved.

Final Words

The Delight of Connection

Relationships take work – and few personality types are more motivated than Protagonists to invest the energy, attention, commitment, and care required to sustain deep, meaningful relationships. For Protagonists, connecting with other people isn't a trivial concern – it's a core purpose of their lives.

But as Protagonists know, the "work" of cultivating these connections doesn't have to feel like drudgery. Protagonists dedicate so much of themselves to their relationships because they genuinely want to. They light up in the company of other people, and they take sincere enjoyment in breaking beneath the surface and discovering what the world looks like through another person's eyes. To a Protagonist, just about anyone can be fascinating, and these types' warmth and encouragement can help even the most retiring of people feel seen and understood.

In these pages, we've discussed how Protagonists can enhance their friendships, their romantic relationships, and their relationships with their children. Along the way, we've covered how Protagonists can understand and address challenges that they might face – such as staying involved without getting over-invested or making sure that their own needs are being met by their relationships. Our hope is that these insights will help you to develop the balanced, life-affirming, meaningful relationships that make life all the more worth living.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you better understand and strengthen your relationships? Explore our Relationship Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Protagonist Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Protagonist Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

All contents copyright ©2011–2023 NERIS Analytics Limited. All rights reserved. This document is intended for personal use only and no part of it may be translated, shared, reproduced or transmitted in any form, by any means (electronic, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the publisher.

The publisher has used its best efforts in preparing this document, and the information provided herein is provided "as is." NERIS Analytics Limited will assume no liability nor responsibility to any person or entity with respect to any loss or damage related directly or indirectly to the information in this document (including any action or inaction taken or not taken as result of the information contained herein). Any decisions that you make once you have read this document are for you alone and we won't be liable for the consequences of any such decisions.

No warranties of any kind, express or implied, are made, and the publisher specifically disclaims any implied warranties of fitness for any particular purpose. The publisher will provide no remedy for indirect, consequential, punitive, incidental, or other damages arising from this document, including such from negligence, strict liability, or breach of warranty or contract, even after notice of the possibility of such damages.

The publisher is not engaged in rendering legal, medical, financial, or other professional services. The information in this document is educational in nature, is provided only as general information, and is not psychological advice. Transmission of this information is not intended to create, and receipt doesn't constitute a psychologist-client relationship. Furthermore, this information is not intended to be used to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or psychological disorder.

This document is only available for purchase at https://www.16personalities.com. If you have downloaded this document from any other website or if it has been included in any service not provided by NERIS Analytics Limited, please be aware this is very likely an unauthorized copy. In such and similar cases, we would be very grateful if you could get in touch with us via our website at https://www.16personalities.com/contact-us so that we could investigate. Thank you!